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Kejriwal questions govt over Ram Temple row

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'It truly felt like a homecoming'

India, Japan unveil broad economic security roadmap amid Indo-Pacific challenges

SIGN STRATEGIC AGREEMENTS SPANNING AI, DEFENCE, ENERGY AND ECONOMIC SECURITY

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Japan's Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi at Hyderabad House, in New Delhi on Thursday ANI

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: Amid escalating strategic competition between the United States and China and growing geopolitical uncertainty in the Indo-Pacific, India and Japan on Thursday unveiled a broad package of strategic agreements that significantly deepen their Special Strategic and Global Partnership. Following summit talks between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi in New Delhi, the two countries announced a joint roadmap on economic security, launched a new artificial intelligence cooperation initiative, signed their first defence co-development project, and expanded cooperation in semiconductors, clean energy, critical minerals and resilient supply chains. The decisions mark a wider shift in bilateral ties, with New Delhi and Tokyo placing economic security, advanced technologies and supply chain resilience at the centre of their partnership while pursuing their shared vision of a free, open and rules-based Indo-Pacific.

CLOSER LOOK

- Joint roadmap targets economic security and resilient supply chains
- New AI initiative expands research, governance and innovation
- India to send 500 AI researchers to Japan by 2030
- First defence co-development project launches naval antenna programme
- Semiconductor cooperation attracts major Japanese investments
- Energy pact strengthens oil security and emergency preparedness

- Japan backs 1,000 biogas plants across India
- Green hydrogen, ammonia and batteries receive fresh push
- JBIC funds renewable energy and Assam bioethanol projects
- Mobility partnership covers shipbuilding, aviation and logistics
- Pharma, biotech and medical cooperation expands
- Over 100 business deals bring USD 10 billion investments
- India seeks 10 trillion yen Japanese investment in 10 years

The agreements were finalised after the 16th India-Japan Annual Summit, held during Takaichi's three-day visit to India from July 1 to 3. The two leaders reviewed cooperation across trade and investment, defence, energy, emerging technologies, science and technology, and people-to-people exchanges before witnessing the exchange of several agreements and memorandums of cooperation.

Addressing the media after the talks, Modi said economic and energy security had become central priorities in an increasingly uncertain world.

"In today's era of uncertainty, both India and Japan fully understand Continued on P4

Monsoon arrives in Delhi; heavy rains kill 6 in Himachal, Mumbai

Women cover themselves amid rainfall, at Noida, in Gautam Buddh Nagar district, Uttar Pradesh, on Thursday PTI

Floods and landslides disrupt life across India

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The southwest monsoon gathered pace across large parts of India on Thursday, ending prolonged heat and humidity in several regions but also causing widespread disruption, flash floods and landslides that claimed at least six lives in Himachal Pradesh and Maharashtra. Heavy rain affected transport, stranded pilgrims, damaged infrastructure and prompted weather alerts across multiple states, while authorities stepped up disaster preparedness as the monsoon advanced further across the country.

Four rain-related deaths were reported from Himachal Pradesh. According to the State Emergency Operations Centre, three people died in separate incidents in Shimla and Chamba districts, while another death was reported from Mandi district.

KEY POINTS

- Himachal Pradesh reported four rain-related deaths across Shimla, Chamba, Mandi, and Lahaul-Spiti
- Flash floods in Chamba stranded around 30 pilgrims after a wooden bridge washed away
- Orange alert issued for heavy to very heavy rainfall in Himachal Pradesh till July 5
- Mumbai man died after falling into an uncovered manhole during heavy rain

Among the victims was Gyan Chand, a bus conductor from Mandi district, who was killed in the Udaipur area of Lahaul and Spiti district after stones falling from a hillside struck him Continued on P4

BJP will get neither donations, nor votes

Akhilesh Yadav

DEFENDS THE CENTRE'S FUEL PRICING POLICY

Fuel price reduction possible only if global crude stays low for 2–3 months, says Puri

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: Defending the government's fuel pricing policy, Union Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri on Thursday said the Modi government shielded consumers from sharp increases in petrol, diesel and LPG prices while ensuring uninterrupted supplies of crude oil, LPG and natural gas despite geopolitical disruptions.

However, Puri indicated there may not be any immediate cut in retail fuel prices. He said petrol and diesel prices do not move in line with daily fluctuations in international crude oil prices because of the time required for procurement, transportation and refining.

TAKEAWAYS

- Retail fuel prices lag global crude movements due to procurement and refining cycles
- Price review may be considered if crude remains low for 2-3 months
- Delhi petrol prices rose 5.58% between June 2022 and June 2026

"The oil currently being sold has been refined using crude bought several weeks, if not months, earlier at higher prices. As long as global crude prices remain low and stable, consumers will eventually benefit, although there is always a delay," he said.

Puri said any decision on reducing retail fuel prices would depend on how long the current trend in global crude prices continues.

"As mentioned earlier, the companies still have stock that was bought when the cost of crude oil, insurance and freight charges was much higher. If the trend continues for another two to three months, it would be time to reconsider retail prices. Continued on P4

'Methyl Isocyanate of Law': SC quashes verdict based on AI-generated precedents

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday struck down a National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) order in the Essel Infraprojects insolvency case after finding that it relied on fake and AI-generated judicial precedents, declaring that courts must adopt a "zero tolerance" approach towards the use of "non-existent, fake, and hallucinated" judgments in legal proceedings.

> The verdict said courts must maintain complete integrity in the decision-making process and warned that citing AI-generated precedents without verification amounts to professional misconduct

A bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe set aside the NCLT Mumbai order, which had admitted a Section 7 insolvency application in a dispute involving Pooja Ramesh Singh, Jammu and Kashmir Bank Ltd and Essel Infraprojects Ltd. The court found that several precedents cited by the tribunal to support its decision simply did not exist and appeared to have been generated through artificial intelligence tools.

Describing the consequences of relying on fabricated legal authorities, the bench said, "The production of fake, non-existent, and hallucinated material and its utilisation as precedents in law, is like the release of methyl Isocyanate in the province of law and justice: invisible, insidious, and catastrophic by the time anyone notices. It not only contaminates but takes away the very life-blood of judicial determination." Continued on P4

NATURE'S CANVAS

A rainbow stretches across the sky over the mountains following rain, in Kullu, on Thursday PTI

Govt fast-tracks disinvestment process to shore up revenues

Garners 31% of budget aim in Q1 FY27

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre has made a strong start to its disinvestment and asset monetisation programme in the current financial year, raising nearly 31 per cent of its full-year Budget target in the first quarter as it looks to strengthen non-tax revenues amid rising expenditure pressures.

According to government data, Rs 24,928 crore has been mobilised so far through disinvestment and asset monetisation against the Budget Estimate of Rs 80,000 crore for FY27. The amount includes Rs 18,561 crore raised through stake sales in public sector enterprises and another Rs 6,367 crore through asset monetisation under the Infrastructure Investment Trust (InvIT) route.

The pace of disinvestment during the first quarter has been the fastest recorded in the opening quarter of any financial year. Between mid-May and June, the government launched one offer for sale every week, selling stakes in six public sector companies. These included Central Bank of India, Coal India, NHPC, NLC India, GIC and IRFC.

The government has already prepared a pipeline of public sector companies for stake sales during the rest of the fiscal and is aiming to surpass the Rs 80,000 crore target.

Among the major transactions expected this year is a further stake sale in Life Insurance Corporation (LIC). The government currently owns 96.5 per cent of the insurance giant and must reduce its holding to 90 per cent by May next year. In May 2022, it had raised Rs 20,500 crore by selling a 3.5 per cent stake in LIC. Continued on P4

Seven workers killed as massive rock collapses at Bengaluru quarry

MPOST BUREAU

BENGALURU: Seven migrant labourers, including five from Madhya Pradesh, were killed and five others injured after a huge granite rock slid down from the top of a quarry and crashed onto workers below in Bengaluru Urban district on Thursday. Police said the incident appeared to have been caused by negligence.

The accident occurred at a quarry in Madapattana, located in Bengaluru Urban district near the border with Bengaluru South district. Initial police information had suggested that most of the victims were from Bihar, but officials later clarified that five of those killed were from Madhya Pradesh, one was from Chhattisgarh and another was from Yadgir in Karnataka.

Deputy Inspector General of Police (Central Range) S Girish said around 16 labourers were working at the quarry when the accident took place. According to him, the quarry had two crushing units, one situated at the top and another below, with work underway at both locations.

"There are two crushers here, one is on the top and the second one is below. There was work going on at both the sites. There were about 16 labourers working there. A drilling machine was deployed on the top. A massive rock slid from the top and fell on the people working below. Continued on P4

CENTRE EXPANDS CLAA FRAMEWORK

Govt brings stem cell, gene therapies under central licensing framework

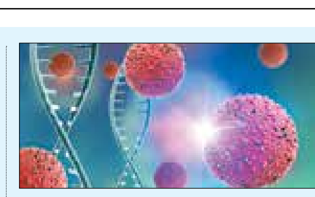
OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre has amended the Drugs Rules, 1945, bringing cell or stem cell-derived products, gene therapeutic products and xenografts under the Centrally Licensed Approving Authority (CLAA) framework to strengthen regulatory oversight of advanced medical technologies.

According to the Union Health Ministry, the change expands the list of products that require joint regulatory supervision by the central and state authorities under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act. Until now, the CLAA framework covered critical drugs and biological products such as vaccines, large-volume parenterals and recombinant DNA (r-DNA)-based medicines. With the latest amendment, the framework will also regulate a wider range of emerging healthcare technologies.

CLOSER LOOK

- Centre amends Drugs Rules, 1945 to tighten oversight of advanced medical technologies
- Cell and stem cell-derived products now fall under the CLAA framework
- Gene therapeutic products have also been brought under CLAA regulation



- Xenografts are now subject to joint central and state regulatory oversight
- CLAA previously covered vaccines, large volume parenterals and r-DNA medicines

The ministry said cell or stem cell-derived products, including stem cell-based regenerative therapies and CAR-T Continued on P4

Board exam marks may get 50% weightage in NEET, JEE admissions

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Board examination marks may account for 50 per cent of the weightage in admissions to professional courses that are currently decided mainly through entrance examinations such as NEET and JEE, according to sources familiar with the discussions.

The proposal is being considered as part of a broader effort to reduce the pressure associated with a single high-stakes examination, whether it is a board exam or an entrance test. The discussions come after concerns over the examination system following incidents such as paper leaks and evaluation errors, which have raised questions about its reliability.

"The changes being contemplated are 50 per cent weightage for board marks in admission or merit, closer alignment of entrance tests with school syllabi to reduce dependence Continued on P4

'ISI HANDLERS USED SOCIAL MEDIA TO RECRUIT OPERATIVES'

ISI-backed terror module busted, four apprehended by Delhi Police

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Four alleged operatives of an ISI-backed terror and arms network have been arrested for allegedly planning a terror attack in Delhi-NCR, taking directions from Pakistani handlers via social media platforms, a Delhi Police official said on Thursday.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Special Cell) Praveen Kumar Tripathi said the investigation has revealed a wider cross-border conspiracy involving the supply of arms and narcotics through drones and the recruitment of local youth for terror-related activities.

Upon their arrest, police recovered two foreign-made pistols, nine live cartridges and five mobile phones. Police said one of the accused was tasked with conducting reconnaissance of police establishments and religious places. The accused Shubdeep Singh alias Vishal (23), Gurjant Singh alias Rishi (22), Sajan Singh alias Honey (28), and Gaganpreet (24) are all residents of Punjab.

"The module was being directed by Pakistan-based ISI handler Shahzad Bhatti and his associates, who allegedly recruited youths from Punjab and supplied them with foreign phone numbers to evade detection by security agencies. They were in regular contact with the ISI-backed network and were allegedly tasked with carrying out a terror activity in Delhi," Tripathi said in a statement.

A Special Cell conducted the operation following specific intelligence inputs, and police carried out multiple raids in Delhi and Punjab.

"The first arrest was made on Majitha Road in Amritsar, where Shubdeep Singh was apprehended and police recovered a semi-automatic pistol, five live cartridges and two mobile phones from him. During interrogation, Shubdeep disclosed that he was in contact with Pakistan-based handlers linked to Shahzad Bhatti and had been receiving consignments of arms and narcotic substances dropped across the border through drones," the DCP said.

Based on his disclosure, police arrested his associates Gurjant Singh and Sajan Singh from Punjab. A Zigana pistol, four live cartridges and two mobile phones were recovered from them, police said.

Subsequently, police arrested Gaganpreet on April 24 in Delhi and recovered a mobile phone allegedly containing incriminating material.

"Gaganpreet was assigned the task of conducting reconnaissance of religious places and police establishments in Delhi. Pakistan-based handlers instructed him to execute a firing incident in the national capital," Tripathi said.

According to police, Shubdeep, a resident of Tarn Taran located around three kilometres from the India-Pakistan border, allegedly received consignments of pistols and narcotic substances through drones and used foreign numbers to communicate with Pakistani handlers and drone operators. Earlier, Punjab Police had arrested him in a case under the NDPS Act.

Police said Gurjant Singh was allegedly in constant touch with ISI handlers through foreign numbers and, along with his cousin Sajan Singh, received arms and narcotics consignments sent from Pakistan using drones.

Sajan Singh, a resident of Amritsar, was also allegedly using foreign numbers to remain in contact with Pakistani handlers. He, too, had previously been arrested by the Punjab Police in an NDPS case.

Police said Gaganpreet was allegedly communicating with Pakistani handlers through social media platforms and had been assigned to record videos of police stations and police pickets in Delhi before carrying out a firing attack.

"Further investigation is underway to identify other members of the network and trace its logistical and financial links," Tripathi said.

HIGHLIGHTS

- 'During interrogation, Shubdeep disclosed he was in contact with Pak-based handlers linked to Shahzad Bhatti'
- 'He'd been receiving consignments of arms and narcotic substances dropped across the border through drones' the DCP said

DFS to add eight stations in 6 months, eyes AI tech upgrade

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Fire Services plans to expand its footprint across the national capital, with eight new fire stations slated to open in the next six months, and drone-based surveillance and firefighting technology upgrade will be part of an ambitious 25-year modernisation roadmap, officials said on Thursday.

Besides infrastructural expansion, Delhi Fire Services (DFS) is preparing to integrate advanced technologies -- such as Artificial Intelligence (AI), GPS, GIS and drones -- into its firefighting operations to improve response times and situational awareness during emergencies.

Chief Fire Officer Abhilash Malik said the department has initiated the expansion of eight fire stations over the next six months at Rohini Sector-41, Geeta Colony, Anand Parbat, Yamuna Vihar, Dwarka Sector-3, Dwarka Sector-20, IFC Narela and Budhanpur Majra.

"The city still has several areas without dedicated fire stations, which leads to delays as fire tenders have to travel longer distances to reach incident sites," Malik stated.

Land for these projects has already been acquired, and work is underway, he said.

DFS officials said the department plans to add eight fire stations annually. Work on eight new stations has already begun as the department seeks to bridge a major infrastructure gap and eventually meet the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA)-mandated target of 120 fire stations in Delhi.

Officials said the long-term action plan is divided into immediate, medium-term and long-term phases, focusing on strengthening infrastructure, manpower and technology.

Currently, the DFS operates with 2,459 personnel across 71 fire stations, far below the MHA norm of around 24,000 personnel and 120 fire stations for a city like Delhi, officials said. The DFS has also identified nine more sites with the Delhi Development Authority (DDA), including in Rohini, Sultanpuri, Mahipalpur, Pitampura, Sarai Rohilla and Golden Park on Rohtak Road, and has sought their handover.

Additionally, land has been requested for 14 more sites under Delhi Development Authority (DDA's) zonal plans, including Burari, Karala, Mundka Industrial Area, Sonia Vihar, Karawal Nagar Industrial Area, Mandoli Industrial Area, Kapashera and Aya Nagar. Under DDA's urbanisation plan for 48 villages, the department has sought land for 28 more fire stations, with Nizampur and Mundhela Kalan already confirmed.

The DFS is reviewing its plan to strengthen its manpower by recruiting 12,174 additional personnel. This recruitment aims to meet staffing requirements for existing stations and ensure manpower is sanctioned alongside new fire stations.

The MHA prescribes 131 personnel per fire station, and in the long term, the DFS plans to build an operational workforce of 48,000 personnel working in eight-hour shifts over the next 25 years.

Officials said the DFS plans to establish a centralised command and control centre within a year, equipped with AI, GPS and GIS-based systems, besides separate command centres in each of its five operational zones. Officials said within the next two years, the department will begin analysing the use of drones for surveillance and firefighting operations, with plans to deploy drones capable of transmitting live video feeds directly to command centres over the next five years.

'Pakistan failing to protect minorities,' says Arvinder Lovely after Gurdwara demolition

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chairman of the Trans-Yamuna Area Development Board, Sardar Arvinder Singh Lovely, on Thursday condemned the demolition of a more than 100-year-old Gurdwara in Pakistan, alleging that the neighbouring country has failed to protect its minority communities and their places of worship.

In a statement, Lovely said, "Pakistan pretends to be the saviour of minorities across the world, yet minorities and their religious places in its own country are not safe." He described the demolition as an attack on the rights and religious sentiments of minority communities and said such actions deserved the strongest condemnation.

He also welcomed the response of the Central Government, saying the Modi government had acted promptly by taking cognisance of the incident. According to Lovely, the government conveyed a strong message to Pakistan and urged it to reconstruct the demolished Gurdwara.

Highlighting the heritage aspect of the issue, Lovely said the demolition was also contrary to international heritage protection norms. "What has happened in Pakistan is also a violation of UNESCO norms," he said.

Explaining his remarks, Lovely stated that, under UNESCO guidelines, it is the responsibility of every country to preserve religious sites that are more than 100 years old. He added that any alteration or demolition of the original structure of such heritage sites amounts to a violation of these norms.

Lovely further alleged that this was not an isolated incident, claiming Pakistan had previously interfered with religious places belonging to minority communities. He said such actions repeatedly hurt the religious sentiments of minorities and reflected the country's failure to safeguard its religious and cultural heritage.

The statement comes amid concerns over the reported demolition of the century-old Gurdwara in Pakistan, with the issue drawing criticism from political leaders in India and renewed calls for the protection and restoration of religious heritage sites.

UG admission process begins at AUD

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Dr. B. R. Ambedkar University Delhi (AUD) on Thursday commenced the undergraduate admission process for the 2026-27 academic session, with admissions to be conducted on the basis of the Common University Entrance Test (CUET-UG) 2026 scores.

According to the university, admissions are open for 23 undergraduate programmes offered under the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 framework. Students can choose between three-year undergraduate degrees and four-year undergraduate programmes, depending on the course structure. The university has announced a total intake of 1,194 seats across various disciplines.

Candidates who appeared for CUET (UG) 2026 are eligible to apply, subject to programme-specific eligibility requirements prescribed by the university. Applicants have been advised to carefully review the admission guidelines before submitting their applications.

The university has urged candidates to verify the programme-wise eligibility criteria, reservation policy, fee structure, list of required documents and the admission schedule to ensure a smooth application process. It has also advised students to complete their applications well before the deadline to avoid last-minute technical difficulties.

Detailed information regarding admissions, eligibility, counselling and other updates is available on the official admission portal of Ambedkar University Delhi. The university is expected to issue further notifications regarding subsequent stages of the admission process in the coming weeks.

Admissions open for 23 programmes with 1,194 seats

Delhi Police apprehend man over hoax bomb threat emails

'Gzb man traced via digital trail'

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have apprehended a 36-year-old man from Ghaziabad in connection with a series of hoax bomb threat emails sent to several high-security organisations, including the National Investigation Agency (NIA), Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO), Nuclear Power Corporation of India Limited (NPCIL), the Ministry of Civil Aviation and an Air India flight from New Delhi to New York.

The emails, sent on June 29, triggered security checks and alerts across multiple agencies.

All threats were later found to be hoaxes. A technical investigation traced the emails to Nishant Tyagi of Sanyog Nagar, Ghaziabad, through mobile numbers linked to the email accounts. Police said Tyagi has been undergoing treatment for mental illness since 2008. No explosives or suspicious material were recovered during the inquiry. The investigation is underway to establish the motive behind the emails and determine further legal action. MPOST

Police: Woman held after husband found strangled in E Delhi

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 20-year-old woman has been arrested by the Delhi Police for allegedly strangling her husband to death following a domestic dispute in East Delhi's Rashid Market. The deceased has been identified as Mustakeem alias Sahil (20), while the accused, Alisha (20), is his wife. Both were residents of Rashid Market.

The incident came to light in the early hours of Wednesday after a PCR call was received at Jagatpuri Police Station at around 3.52 am, reporting that a woman had allegedly strangled her husband.

A police team led by ASI Hemant rushed to the spot and found Mustakeem unconscious. He was taken to Dr Hedgewar Hospital, where doctors declared him brought dead. Based on a complaint lodged by the deceased's mother, the police registered an FIR under Section 103(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), and the investigation was handed over to Inspector Abhishek Kumar Singh.

Investigators examined the crime scene, recorded witness statements and analysed the available evidence. During questioning, Alisha allegedly confessed to the crime.

According to the police, the accused told investigators that her husband suspected her of having an extramarital affair and had taken her mobile phone during the night to search for evidence. The argument allegedly escalated into a physical altercation, during which the victim assaulted her. In retaliation, she allegedly sat on his chest and strangled him with her dupatta.

Police said the deceased's mother entered the room shortly after the incident, following which the accused fled the house and hid inside a gurdwara in an attempt to evade arrest. She was later apprehended from the religious premises.

The dupatta allegedly used in the crime was recovered and seized as the weapon of offence.

Officials said prompt police action, forensic examination of the scene and sustained interrogation enabled the case to be solved within hours. Further investigation is underway.

'The dupatta used in the crime was recovered, seized'

Noida's 1st lake park set to take shape in Sector 167

DIPIKA KIROLA

'A key attraction will be two elevated walkways extending over the lake, allowing visitors to walk above the water and enjoy panoramic views of the waterbody. Park is being developed as a major recreational and eco-tourism destination'

NOIDA: Noida's first large lake park is set to move forward after Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath recently laid the foundation stone for the project. Officials said the Noida Authority is preparing to begin the tendering process for the ambitious green initiative in Sector 167.

Spread across 29 acres, the park will feature a 10-acre artificial lake as its centrepiece and is estimated to cost around Rs 21 crore. Officials said the design has been finalised and tenders are expected to be floated shortly.

A key attraction will be two elevated walkways extending over the lake, allowing visitors to walk above the water and enjoy panoramic views from the middle of the waterbody. The park is being developed as a major recreational and eco-tourism destination.

Planned under the "Life Breathe Jungle" concept, the project aims to increase Noida's green cover and improve air quality. The plantation plan includes 2,294 banyan trees, 2,900 peepal trees, 3,800 neem trees, 3,240 pilkhan trees and 1,590 tamarind trees. An "oxygen valley" has also been proposed as part of the ecological landscape.

Noida Authority Additional Chief Executive Officer Vandana Tripathi said the park will have an open parking area near the main entrance with space for around 1,000 vehicles. Other proposed facilities include walking and cycling tracks, an open gym, a central plaza, fountains, a children's play area and a dedicated food street.

"The project is expected to become Noida's first and largest public park centred around a waterbody. Besides providing a new recreational space for residents, it is also aimed at strengthening the city's environmental sustainability through large-scale plantation and the creation of urban green infrastructure," Tripathi said.

The authority is expected to invite bids in the coming weeks, after which construction timelines will be finalised. Once completed, the lake park is expected to become a major destination for leisure, picnics and outdoor activities in the city.

MORE DESTINATIONS TO BE ADDED THIS MONTH

IndiGo adds nine new destinations within wks of Noida Airport launch

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: Just over two weeks after commercial operations began at Noida International Airport, IndiGo has expanded its domestic network by adding nine new destinations. The airline now operates flights to 13 cities from the airport, with more routes scheduled to be introduced this month.

The newly launched services connect Noida with Jaipur, Jodhpur, Bhopal, Dehradun, Dharamshala, Pantnagar, Bareilly, Lucknow and Chandigarh. Flights to Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Jammu and Amritsar were already operational. IndiGo's direct service to Navi Mumbai, originally scheduled to begin this week, will now commence on July 10, while flights to Srinagar are expected to start later this month, officials said.

Noida International Airport began commercial passenger operations on June 15, with IndiGo as its launch carrier. The airport is expected to gradually expand its domestic network before international services begin later this year.

Officials said the increase in flight operations has led to a rise in passenger footfall.

To strengthen last-mile connectivity, around 50 electric buses were deployed on Wednesday from various parts of Noida and Greater Noida to the airport. Uttar Pradesh and Haryana Roadways buses, along with taxi services operated by Mahindra Logistics and other operators, are also available for passengers.

Nodal officer Shailendra Bhatia said IndiGo also launched flights to Kishangarh on Thursday. He added that the Chandigarh schedule will be revised from July 13, with flights operating only on Mondays and Tuesdays.

Airport officials said aircraft operations have also become more efficient, with flights now using both the eastern and western ends of the runway for take-offs and landings, instead of operating in a single direction.

Akasa Air, the second airline operating from Noida International Airport, currently offers flights to Mumbai and Bengaluru.

"Ops have also become more efficient, with flights now using both the eastern and western ends of the runway

Police arrest notorious snatcher after gunfight

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Anti Auto Theft Squad (AATS) of the Delhi Police arrested a 26-year-old alleged habitual snatcher following a brief exchange of gunfire near Sannoth village in the Narela Industrial Area.

The accused, identified as Irshad Ali alias Sukar Ali alias Shankar Ali, a resident of JJ Colony in Bawana, was apprehended after police received a tip-off about his movement and laid a trap in the area.

According to the police, Irshad allegedly opened fire while attempting to evade arrest after being asked to surrender.

Police retaliated in self-defence, during which he sustained a gunshot injury to his leg. No police personnel were injured.

He was initially taken to a hospital in Narela and later referred to a hospital in Rohini. His condition is stated to be stable. Police recovered a stolen Bajaj Vikrant motorcycle from his possession, which was found to be linked to a theft case registered at Narela Police Station.

Officials said Irshad has a criminal record involving around 49 cases, including robbery, snatching, theft, attempt to murder, culpable homicide, offences under the Arms Act and assault on a public servant. A fresh case has been registered, and further interrogation is underway.

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OVER REGULATORY ASSETS ISSUE

Delhi orders CAG audit of discoms

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major move aimed at bringing greater transparency and accountability to Delhi's power sector, the Delhi government has formally ordered a Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) audit of the Capital's three private electricity distribution companies (discoms). The government said the audit will examine the financial and regulatory aspects of the discoms' operations, including the build-up of regulatory assets estimated at nearly Rs 38,000 crore. The audit, ordered under the provisions of the Comptroller and Auditor General's (Duties, Powers and Conditions of Service) Act, 1971, will cover BSES Rajdhani Power Limited (BRPL), BSES Yamuna Power Limited (BYPL) and Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL).

Welcoming the development, Delhi Power Minister Ashish Sood said, "The formal order for the CAG audit of Delhi's discoms is a historic step towards transparency, accountability and good governance in Delhi's power sector. More importantly, it is a victory for every electricity consumer and every honest taxpayer of Delhi."

He alleged that financial decisions and growing liabilities in the power sector had escaped public scrutiny for years after electricity distribution was privatised. "What the previous AAP government could not do in ten years, our government has initiated within a few months," he said.

Sood said Delhi residents have a right to know "how regulatory assets worth nearly Rs 38,000 crore kept increasing and who benefited while the burden ultimately fell on the people of Delhi." He added that the audit would bring these facts into the public domain.

Calling the exercise more than an investigation into the previous government's functioning, Sood said, "This audit is the foundation for comprehensive reforms in Delhi's power sector. Its true success will depend on the corrective measures, stronger regulation and enhanced accountability that follow."

The government said the decision follows the Supreme Court's August 6, 2025 judgment directing a strict audit of the circumstances under which discoms continued operations without recovery of regulatory assets. The CAG has been asked to complete the audit within three months, while all three discoms have been directed to provide full cooperation and all necessary records.

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The formal order for the CAG audit of Delhi's discoms is a historic step towards transparency, accountability and good governance in Delhi's power sector: Minister
- » 'More importantly, it is a victory for every electricity consumer and every honest taxpayer of Delhi'
- » He alleged that financial decisions and growing liabilities in the power sector had escaped public scrutiny for years after electricity distribution was privatised, says Sood

Private schools must justify fee hike: Sood

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Private schools in the capital will have to justify any proposed fee hike on 18 prescribed parameters, including infrastructure development, transportation, safety measures and staff recruitment, and satisfy parents that the increase is warranted, Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood said on Thursday.

The minister said the Delhi government has directed all private unaided schools to constitute a School Level Fee Regulation Committee (SLFRCs) by July 15 under the Delhi School Education (Transparency in Fixation and Regulation of Fees) Act, 2025, warning of strict action against institutions that fail to comply.

Sood said the government is committed to making quality education affordable and accessible, and asserted that education is "a noble service to society, not a commercial business".

Under the new framework, schools seeking a fee revision will have to place their proposal before the committee and justify the increase on 18 parameters prescribed under the rules, he said. "These include expenditure on infrastructure development, transportation facilities, school buildings, safety measures, lighting, staff recruitment and other institutional requirements. Schools will have to demonstrate that the proposed hike is linked to genuine improvements and is supported by financial records," the minister said.

According to a statement, every private unaided school must constitute an SLFRC comprising representatives of students' guardians, teachers and the school management. The selection of five guardian representatives and three teacher representatives will be carried out through a public, video-recorded draw of lots after giving a mandatory seven-day public notice. The process will be monitored by a government-appointed observer.

"Any attempt by school managements to influence the draw or bypass the prescribed procedure would invite strict action, including monetary penalties, withdrawal of school recognition or even a government takeover of the school's management," it stated.

School managements have been directed to submit their proposed fee structures for the next three years to the committees by July 31, it stated, adding that the proposals must be supported by audited financial statements for the previous three years certified by a chartered accountant. Unaudited or self-certified financial records will not be accepted. The statement also said in compliance with interim orders of the Delhi High Court, private schools will continue to charge fees at the same rate as in the 2025-26 academic session until their revised fee structures are examined and approved by the regulatory committees.

Any excess fee collected during the interim period will be subject to the final outcome of the court proceedings and will have to be refunded or adjusted accordingly.

The Directorate of Education has instructed regional directors and district officials to ensure strict implementation of the new provisions, saying the interests of students and guardians remain the government's priority.

Govt clears 945 Lakhpati Bitiya applications in three months

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: Delhi government has approved 945 new applications under the Lakhpati Bitiya Scheme in the three months since it went online in April. To boost awareness and encourage more eligible families to enrol, the government plans to roll out metro jingles, school outreach programmes and district-level training initiatives.

The upgraded scheme, which replaced the Ladli Scheme in April, now has over 9.32 lakh active beneficiaries since its launch in 2008, a Women and Child Development (WCD) official said.

Existing beneficiaries have been automatically migrated to the new framework, while fresh enrolments are being processed through a dedicated online portal.

"Creating awareness remains the biggest challenge as many eligible families are still unaware of the revised provisions, particularly the expanded benefits available for girls pursuing graduation and professional diploma courses," the official said.

To increase enrolment, the department has already issued newspaper advertisements and is preparing information, education and communication material, including posters, pamphlets, and leaflets, for distribution across districts. Metro jingles and other public awareness campaigns are also being planned, the official told PTI.

The department will begin training district-level nodal officers from July 4 to familiarise them with the revised provisions. A joint advisory by the WCD and the Education Department is also in process to help schools spread awareness among eligible students, she said.

According to her, the nodal officers will coordinate with schools in their respective districts and explain the scheme's revised features, eligibility conditions and online application process to ensure that more beneficiaries are covered.

Unlike the earlier Ladli Scheme, applications are now submitted entirely online through a dedicated portal.

CM Rekha Gupta unveils Delhi Next

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday launched 'Delhi Next - Code, Create and Change', describing it as the country's largest civic-tech innovation programme aimed at integrating technology-driven solutions from young innovators directly into government systems.

Chairing the event at the Delhi Secretariat, Gupta said the initiative seeks to bring together startups, researchers, educational institutions and youth to develop solutions for Delhi's civic and urban challenges, including traffic management, waterlogging, air pollution, waste management, smart parking, digital governance and public services.

She said, "Governance today cannot remain confined to policymaking alone. The need of the hour is to develop effective and lasting solutions through technology, innovation and public participation."

Highlighting the programme's unique approach, the Chief Minister said, "Unlike conventional hackathons, the selected solutions will not remain limited to demonstrations. They will be implemented as pilot projects with the support of government departments and successful models will be integrated into the government system."

The programme was conducted in three stages. According to the government, an awareness campaign reached over one crore young people across the country, while more than 2.5 lakh participants registered. After evaluation of

over 5,000 technical proposals, 1,000 participants were shortlisted, with the top 60 teams presenting live demonstrations of their working prototypes before the Chief Minister.

The selected teams will receive continued mentoring, departmental support and pilot implementation opportunities. Each team will be assigned to a relevant government department to develop a Minimum Viable Product (MVP) and prepare a roadmap for integrating successful solutions into public administration.

Reiterating the government's vision, Gupta said, "Delhi will become the country's civic-tech capital, where government, startups, industry, educational institutions and citizens work together to create new models of good governance."

She added that the initiative reflects the government's commitment to leveraging data, artificial intelligence, digital innovation and citizen participation to make governance more transparent, accountable and efficient while encouraging young people to contribute to building a "Viksit Delhi."

MCD taps AI talent

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) hosted the Delhi 2.0 Tech Dialogue, where 60 young innovators from across the country presented Artificial Intelligence (AI)-based solutions aimed at improving urban governance and civic service delivery.

Deputy Mayor Dr. Monika Pant interacted with the participants at the Civic Centre and reviewed presentations on AI-powered software developed for key municipal functions, including waste management, waste segregation, parking management, Human Resource Management Systems (HRMS), and labour management. Additional Commissioner Dr. Satendra Singh Dursawat and senior MCD officials were also present.

The participants demonstrated how AI-enabled technologies could help streamline municipal operations by improving efficiency, transparency and accuracy while making public services more citizen-centric. The proposed solutions focused on addressing everyday urban challenges through technology-driven governance.

Speaking at the event, Dr. Pant said the ideas presented by the young innovators reflected the growing role of technology in solving civic issues. She said the MCD would examine the proposals and assess their feasibility for implementation, particularly in waste management and other municipal services.

The Deputy Mayor also emphasised the importance of sustained engagement between the administration and young innovators, describing such interactions as essential for building a smarter and more technology-enabled urban governance system. She said the programme offered students an opportunity to engage directly with policymakers and administrative officials while showcasing innovations with the potential to strengthen public service delivery.

According to the MCD, the Delhi 2.0 Tech Dialogue seeks to connect the innovation potential of young people with governance by promoting the use of emerging technologies to make civic services more efficient, transparent and accountable.

L-G greets Oman's bright minds

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sardar T.S. Sandhu hosted a bright group of young students from Oman at Lok Niwas, Delhi, who emerged as the winners of the Śāstra Pratibhā Contest organised by Vijnana Bharati at IIT Gandhinagar. The interaction centred on the student's scientific curiosity, spirit of inquiry and eagerness to learn.

During the interaction, the Lieutenant Governor emphasised that nurturing a robust scientific temper and analytical thinking among young minds remains vital to building a strong foundation for research, innovation and a futureready society. Encouraging the students to shape their futures with confidence, the Lieutenant Governor advised them to follow their passion and choose a career path that is true to their inner calling. He urged the students to pursue whatever brings them genuine happiness rather than bending to external societal expectations, stressing that their primary focus should be to achieve absolute excellence in whatever path they choose.

Highlighting the changing global landscape, the Lieutenant Governor underscored the importance of continuous skill-learning. He said that academic knowledge must be matched with practical adaptability and placed strong emphasis on the need to constantly acquire new and relevant skills to effectively navigate a rapidly evolving world.Speaking about the importance of resilience, the Lieutenant Governor urged the young innovators to never be afraid of failures. He said that setbacks should never be feared or viewed as defeats but should instead be embraced as essential learning experiences that ultimately make an individual tougher, wiser and stronger. The L-G also commended the dedicated efforts of Vijnana Bharati in inspiring the next generation of young innovators while connecting them with India's rich scientific heritage.

MCD gears up for rains

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Thursday stepped up its sanitation and monsoon preparedness measures, with Delhi Mayor Pravesh Wahi flagging off 75 additional sanitation vehicles for the Keshav Puram Zone and MCD Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar inspecting desilting operations in the Civil Lines Zone.

At a function held at Rani Jhansi Stadium, the Mayor launched a fleet comprising 30 light motor vehicles, eight Hyva trucks, four JCB machines, 30 three-wheelers and three jetting machines. The civic body said the vehicles would strengthen waste collection, transportation, drain cleaning and other sanitation operations in the zone.

Addressing the gathering, Wahi said the induction of modern equipment would improve operational efficiency and enhance sanitation services. He added that similar augmentation of sanitation resources was being carried out across MCD zones as part of efforts to build a cleaner and greener Delhi. Member of Parliament Praveen Khandelwal said effective utilisation of the new machinery would be essential to improving sanitation standards and called for greater public participation in maintaining cleanliness.

Separately, Commissioner Khirwar inspected drains and civic infrastructure in Adarsh Nagar to assess monsoon preparedness. During the visit, he directed officials to expedite desilting work near Adarsh Nagar and Majlis Park Metro stations and remove accumulated silt without delay.

The Commissioner also instructed officials to install additional dustbins near Adarsh Nagar Metro Station without disrupting traffic movement and ordered action against illegal commercial activities contributing to drain blockage.

DDA plans over 54 acre amusement park in Rohini

New Delhi: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has planned a large-scale amusement park in Delhi's Rohini to boost recreational activities, officials said on Thursday.

According to officials, the proposed project will come up on a piece land measuring approximately 54.7 acres in Sector 34, Rohini.

"We have floated a tender inviting companies to develop and maintain the amusement park. The successful bidder will get development and operational rights for a period of 55 years. The project is envisioned as a major leisure destination catering to residents of Delhi and national capital region (NCR)," an official said. MPOST

E-rickshaw row triggers probe

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: After videos surfaced on social media showing e-rickshaws being shut down using a Chinese app, Delhi transport minister Pankaj Singh said on Thursday that the government is looking into the matter. Singh said it is illegal and police will likely take action.

"We are aware of the matter on social media and the government is looking into it. I believe police will also take action on their own about this, as it is illegal to do so," Singh told PTI videos. The transport minister said under the "Delhi Electric Vehicle Policy 2026", more electric vehicle adoption will happen through the incentives and other facilities given.

"I believe that now EV cars are coming in a lower price range also. We are providing incentives for scrapping and purchasing. Gradually, for those with a higher range, when people start adopting EVs, their value will also reduce as competition will increase for cars," the minister told PTI videos.

> 'We are aware of the matter on social media and the govt is looking into it. I believe police will also take action on their own about this'

Delhiites will be eligible for scrapping incentives of up to Rs 1 lakh if they buy a new electric vehicle within six months of scrapping their old one, according to the notified Delhi EV Policy. The incentive is linked to the Certificate of Deposit (CoD), which can be obtained upon scrapping an old vehicle at an authorised facility.

Singh assured that there will be enough charging points across the city, as the government plans to install around 32,000 charging points in the next four years.

"I assure the people of Delhi that there will be no problem with the infrastructure. We will install approximately 30,000 charging points in the next four years. With the implementation of the EV policy, people should switch to EVs, to electric vehicles. They will not face any problem anywhere, neither with charging nor with infrastructure," the minister said.

Under its EV policy, the Delhi government announced that all electric cars with an ex-showroom price of Rs 30 lakh or less registered in the national capital will get full exemption on road tax and registration fees.

SIR drive picks up

NEW DELHI: The Election Commission's Special Intensive Revision (SIR) Phase III of electoral rolls in Delhi gathered momentum, with more than 21 lakh enumeration forms distributed across the national capital within the first three days of the month-long exercise. According to the cumulative status report released on Thursday, a total of 21,02,079 enumeration forms had been distributed by 8 pm on July 2, covering 14.49 per cent of Delhi's 1.45 crore electors. The enumeration phase began on June 30 and will continue until July 29.

The revision exercise aims to ensure that "no eligible citizen is left out while no ineligible person is included in the electoral roll." Among the districts, North recorded the highest distribution percentage at 22.13 per cent, with 2.15 lakh forms distributed. New Delhi district followed at 20.94 per cent, while North West registered 19.78 per cent. Old Delhi reported 15.40 per cent distribution, followed by North East at 15.51 per cent.

In terms of absolute numbers, North East distributed the highest number of forms at 2.90 lakh, followed by North West with 2.52 lakh and North with 2.15 lakh. The report also showed that 63,620 enumeration forms had been digitised so far, accounting for 0.44 per cent of the total electorate. Outer North recorded the highest digitisation rate at 0.88 per cent, followed by South West at 0.84 per cent and Central North at 0.63 per cent. MPOST

OCUSES ON COMMERCIAL DRIVERS AND MIDDLE-CLASS FAMILIES

NEW EV POLICY 2026 PUTS SAVINGS FIRST

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government on Thursday pitched its new Electric Vehicle (EV) Policy 2026 as a major financial relief package for commuters, commercial drivers and small businesses, promising savings of up to Rs 1.5 lakh on eligible electric vehicles while shifting the focus from private car buyers to working families and livelihood-based transport.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the policy was designed not only to accelerate Delhi's transition to clean mobility but also to make electric vehicles financially attractive for ordinary citizens. "The Delhi EV Policy 2026 is not just a step towards a cleaner environment, but also a people-centric policy designed with the financial interests of ordinary citizens in mind," she said. "The policy aims to reduce not only the upfront cost of buying an electric vehicle but also its lifetime ownership cost."

Addressing concerns over affordability, Gupta said the biggest question before potential buyers is whether EVs actually save money. "The Delhi EV Policy 2026 provides a clear and positive answer," she said, adding that the policy combines purchase incentives, scrapping incentives, lifetime exemption from road tax, waiver of registration fees and lower operating and maintenance costs.

Under the policy, eligible buyers of electric two-wheelers will receive purchase incentives of up to Rs.30,000 along with a Rs.10,000 scrapping incentive, lifetime road tax exemption and registration fee waiver, resulting in savings of more than Rs.50,000. Electric auto-rickshaw buyers will be eligible for benefits exceeding Rs.75,000, while buyers of electric N-1 goods carriers can save nearly Rs.1.5 lakh through purchase and scrapping incentives, besides tax and registration exemptions. The Chief Minister said private electric cars would not receive purchase incentives. However, owners scrapping a conventional fuel-powered car and purchasing an electric car will be eligible for a scrapping incentive of up to Rs.1 lakh, along with lifetime road tax exemption and a complete waiver of registration fees.

Highlighting the government's priorities, Gupta said, "We have chosen to invest public funds where they can benefit ordinary citizens the most." She added that the policy prioritises two-wheelers, three-wheelers and commercial goods carriers because these vehicles are widely used by lower and middle-income families, commercial drivers, delivery partners and small businesses. The CM also stressed that the road tax exemption would remain valid for the lifetime of the vehicle, while lower electricity and maintenance costs would generate additional long-term savings.

From Page 1

India, Japan unveil broad

the importance of economic security and energy security. With this in mind, we have today prepared a joint roadmap for economic security," he said.

The roadmap seeks to strengthen resilient supply chains in strategic sectors including semiconductors, quantum technology and advanced materials while expanding cooperation in critical minerals, battery supply chains, clean hydrogen and Open RAN technologies. The two governments also agreed to establish a Joint Working Group on critical minerals, continue semiconductor policy dialogue and promote workforce development through the Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA).

Modi said India and Japan viewed "economic security as shared security and the energy transition as a shared opportunity."

The summit also produced one of the most ambitious bilateral frameworks on artificial intelligence. Under the newly announced Japan-India AI Cooperation Initiative (JAI), the two countries will collaborate on AI governance, AI safety, cybersecurity, digital infrastructure, semiconductors, multilingual large language models, research, innovation and human resource development.

The initiative includes research partnerships between IIT Bombay, BharatGen Technology Foundation and Japan's National Institute of Informatics. Indian AI startup Sarvam AI will collaborate with Japan's Preferred Networks on generative AI technologies.

The two countries also committed to facilitating the movement of at least 500 highly skilled Indian AI researchers to Japan by 2030 through research collaborations, internships and employment opportunities.

Highlighting the growing role of technology in bilateral ties, Modi said the convergence of Japan's precision engineering and India's software capabilities would provide fresh momentum to artificial intelligence.

Private sector participation also featured prominently in the discussions, particularly in semiconductors, where Japanese companies are rapidly expanding their presence in India.

Renesas Electronics has invested in the semiconductor packaging plant being set up by CG Power in Sanand, Gujarat, where commercial-scale manufacturing is expected to begin in 2026. The company is also partnering with C-DAC and IIT Hyderabad to support semiconductor research, skill development and startups.

Tokyo Electron has expanded cooperation with Tata Electronics and established an office at Dholera Industrial Park in Gujarat. Fujifilm India plans to build a semiconductor materials manufacturing facility in Dholera, with production expected to begin by 2028.

ROHM has partnered with Tata Electronics and Suchi Semicon to manufacture power semiconductors and integrated circuits in India. MinebeaMitsumi is studying semiconductor manufacturing and railway power semiconductor research in Tamil Nadu, while Nippon Express Holdings is exploring semiconductor logistics systems in Gujarat and Assam.

The two countries also agreed to expand cooperation in digital technologies, telecommunications, quantum computing and digital infrastructure.

Rakuten Symphony and Tejas Networks are jointly developing Open RAN solutions while working on artificial intelligence and machine learning applications. NEC is collaborating with Canara Bank, Reliance Jio, Jumbotail and the Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority on AI-enabled digital platforms and analytics.

NTT is expanding submarine cable and data centre projects across India, while Yaqumo Inc. and the Indian Institute of Science have partnered on quantum technology research. Officials also held technical discussions on intelligent transport systems and vehicle-to-everything technologies.

Energy security emerged as another major pillar of the summit.

India and Japan agreed to strengthen cooperation on strategic petroleum reserves, emergency response mechanisms, energy transportation, upstream investments and institutional coordination involving Indian Strategic Petroleum Reserves Limited, Japan Organisation for Metals and Energy Security, the Japan Bank for International Cooperation and national oil companies.

Modi announced the launch of the India-Japan Bio-gas Initiative, under which Japan will support the establishment of 1,000 biogas and organic fertiliser plants across India.

He said the initiative would strengthen sustainability, rural livelihoods and energy resilience while helping prepare for disruptions such as oil supply shocks.

The two countries also expanded cooperation in batteries, green hydrogen, green ammonia and nuclear energy.

Among the major projects, IHI and ACME will jointly develop a green ammonia facility in Odisha with an annual production capacity of around 400,000 tonnes. Uttar Pradesh and Japan's Yamanashi Prefecture are collaborating on green hydrogen, with Kanadevia and Infistar Energy signing an agreement for hydrogen production.

Itochu Corporation and L&T Energy Green Tech are working together on green ammonia projects. JBIC will provide JPY 80 billion to Power Grid Corporation of India for renewable energy transmission projects and JPY 60 billion for a bioethanol project in Assam.

Sumitomo Corporation and AMPIN Energy are jointly developing renewable energy platforms, while additional collaborations cover electric mobility, industrial gases, renewable power and biofuels.

The summit also marked a milestone in defence cooperation with the signing of the first India-Japan co-development project involving a naval radio antenna.

"This project for a naval radio antenna will open a new chapter in our defence technology partnership. We will now jointly develop defence technologies that will strengthen regional peace, maritime security, and the rules-based order," Modi said.

The two sides also launched the India-Japan Next-Generation Mobility Partnership Framework to expand successful cooperation in the automotive sector into shipbuilding, aviation and logistics.

In healthcare, the two governments signed agreements covering pharmaceuticals, medical devices, biotechnology and healthcare supply chains. Japanese companies including Eisai, Otsuka Pharmaceutical, Takeda, Meiji Seika Pharma and Sysmex are expanding manufacturing and research operations in India. Eisai is setting up an AI-powered drug discovery and pharmaceutical production centre in Visakhapatnam.

Highlighting the growing economic relationship, Modi said more than 100 new business agreements had been signed over the past year, bringing more than USD 10 billion in Japanese investment commitments to India.

"Our goal is clear: to achieve an investment of 10 trillion yen from Japan into India over the next 10 years and to double the number of Japanese companies in India," he said.

Takaichi said both governments were pursuing stronger economic growth through investment and innovation.

"I am committed to realising a strong economy and aiming to enhance Japan's supply chain and technological capabilities through investment in 17 strategic areas," she said, adding that Japan and India shared the goal of building stronger and more prosperous nations through future-oriented investments.

The summit also carried a personal touch. While welcoming Takaichi, Japan's first woman prime minister, Modi referred to her as his "younger sister" and described her as a "visionary and popular leader". Takaichi later responded by saying the two leaders had agreed to develop bilateral ties "as brother and sister".

India and Japan also agreed on a programme of activities to mark the 75th anniversary of diplomatic relations in 2027 through cultural exchanges, tourism and the creative economy.

India and Japan elevated their relationship to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014. With more than 70 dialogue mechanisms now in place, cooperation continues to expand across economic security, defence, technology, clean energy, trade and regional affairs, reflecting the growing strategic convergence between the two countries as they seek to build resilient supply chains, strengthen technological capabilities and support stability in the Indo-Pacific.

Monsoon arrives

during heavy rain.

In Chamba district, flash floods washed away a temporary wooden bridge near a temple in the Bharmour subdivision, leaving around 30 pilgrims stranded. Rescue and relief operations were initiated as authorities monitored the situation.

The Shimla Meteorological Centre has issued an orange alert for heavy to very heavy rainfall at isolated places across Himachal Pradesh from July 2 to July 5, except on July 3.

Mumbai also witnessed severe disruption after intense rain lashed the city through Thursday morning. A 55-year-old man, identified as Shaikh, died after falling into an uncovered manhole, marking the city's second rain-related death this week.

CCTV footage showed the man talking on his mobile phone before walking past a parked tempo and disappearing into the open manhole. Officials said the cover had been temporarily removed by three contractual workers carrying out maintenance work. The workers immediately lowered a ladder into the manhole in an attempt to rescue him but recovered only his umbrella and slippers as strong water currents swept him away.

Following the incident, the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation suspended four civic officials and ordered a high-level inquiry.

Heavy rainfall inundated several parts of Mumbai, including Dadar, Parel, Hindmata, Charkop, Worli, Goregaon and Andheri, slowing road traffic and disrupting the morning commute. Local train services were delayed by 10 to 15 minutes because of water accumulation on tracks, leading to overcrowding during peak office hours.

Meanwhile, Delhi finally welcomed the southwest monsoon after days of intense heat and humidity. The monsoon reached the national capital five days later than its normal onset date, bringing cloudy skies, light rainfall and a noticeable drop in temperatures.

The arrival marked Delhi's first July onset of the monsoon since 2021, when it reached the city on July 13. The India Meteorological Department declared the onset after favourable atmospheric conditions developed over the region.

The weather office has issued a yellow alert for Friday, forecasting generally cloudy skies with moderate rainfall. Minimum and maximum temperatures are expected to remain around 22 degrees Celsius and 32 degrees Celsius, respectively.

According to the IMD, Delhi's Safdarjung observatory recorded a maximum temperature of 33 degrees Celsius on Thursday, which was 4.4 degrees below normal, while the minimum settled at 22.8 degrees Celsius, 5.1 degrees below normal. The city also recorded its lowest minimum temperature since July 21, 2021, when the temperature had dropped to 22.4 degrees Celsius.

Rainfall remained light across monitoring stations. Safdarjung received 4.6 mm of rainfall till 8.30 am, while Palam recorded 1.9 mm and Ayanagar 5 mm. Lodi Road received 4.1 mm and Ridge recorded 3 mm during the same period.

Weather expert Mahesh Palawat of Skymet Weather said recent rainfall over Delhi and parts of north India was triggered by a low-pressure area over Odisha along with an associated cyclonic circulation extending across parts of Madhya Pradesh and southern Sindh.

"The monsoon generally advances along the seasonal trough, which currently stretches from Punjab to the Bay of Bengal," Palawat said.

He said the seasonal trough is expected to shift southwards towards central India from Friday, resulting in increased rainfall over central India, while rainfall activity over Delhi, Punjab and Haryana may temporarily decline.

Palawat also attributed the delayed arrival of the monsoon to the late arrival of humid easterly winds from the Bay of Bengal, which are essential for sustained monsoon rainfall over the capital.

The delayed onset followed a warmer than usual pre-monsoon season in Delhi. IMD data showed the average minimum temperature during the March to June period stood at 22.9 degrees Celsius, the highest seasonal average since 2022. The average maximum temperature during the same period was 37 degrees Celsius, making it the second highest in the last six years after 2024.

Elsewhere, authorities remained on alert as heavy rain continued across several states.

In Gujarat, police reviewed monsoon preparedness and disaster response measures while deploying 1,036 personnel from 11 companies of the State Disaster Response Force.

The National Highways Authority of India said vulnerable highway stretches in Himachal Pradesh prone to landslides, flooding, debris accumulation and slope failures had been identified, with preventive measures taken to keep traffic moving safely during the rainy season.

The Kishtwar district administration in Jammu and Kashmir issued a weather advisory warning of heavy rain, thunderstorms, flash floods and landslides till Sunday. Residents, particularly those living near rivers and vulnerable areas, were advised to remain cautious, while emergency helpline numbers were issued.

In Uttarakhand, moderate to heavy rainfall disrupted movement on the Badrinath National Highway in Chamoli district and the Kedarnath Yatra route in Rudraprayag district after falling debris and stones blocked key stretches. Authorities temporarily suspended the movement of vehicles and pilgrims on the Sonprayag-Munkatiya route.

The flood situation in Assam improved, with the number of affected people falling to over 25,000 across Dhemaji and Dibrugarh districts. According to the Assam State Disaster Management Authority, more than 21,000 affected residents are in Dhemaji district, while the flood-related death toll this year remained unchanged at one.

Punjab and Haryana also received intermittent showers, bringing temperatures well below normal and relief from the scorching heat.

Although the southwest monsoon has now covered the whole of Uttar Pradesh, the state continues to face a 45 per cent seasonal rainfall deficit compared with the long-term average. In Rajasthan, the monsoon advanced into parts of the state seven days later than usual, with the weather office forecasting heavy to very heavy rainfall in several eastern and southeastern districts, including Udaipur, Kota, Ajmer, Bharatpur and Jaipur, over the next five to seven days.

Fuel price reduction

At this stage, however, it is too early to make any predictions," he added.

The minister said retail prices of petrol and diesel have remained largely stable over the past four years despite sharp fluctuations in global crude oil prices. He said petrol prices in Delhi rose from Rs 96.72 per litre in June 2022 to Rs 102.12 per litre in June 2026, an increase of 5.58 per cent, while diesel prices increased by 6.23 per cent during the same period.

"There has been no proportionate increase in retail fuel prices despite higher international crude oil prices," Puri said, adding that the government absorbed much of the impact. He noted that Prime Minister Narendra Modi reduced the central excise duty on petrol and diesel in November 2021, May 2022 and March 2026, resulting in a cumulative reduction of Rs 10 per litre on both fuels.

Puri said public sector oil marketing companies (OMCs) continue to face significant under-recoveries because retail prices have remained controlled. He said under-recoveries in the first quarter of FY2026-27 were estimated at Rs 19,905 crore for petrol, Rs 1,44,819 crore for diesel and Rs 24,148 crore for LPG. Including losses from previous years, the cumulative under-recovery is nearly Rs 2.1 lakh crore, he added.

He said OMCs had remained financially strong until the recent global energy crisis, but sustained high crude oil prices and the government's policy of protecting consumers had affected their balance sheets.

Comparing India's fuel prices with other countries, Puri said petrol prices increased by about 18.39 per cent in some developed countries, 39.77 per cent in Pakistan, 36.6 per cent in Sri Lanka and 20.6 per cent in Nepal, compared with around five per cent in India.

For diesel, he said prices rose 63.18 per cent in Pakistan, 34.57 per cent in Sri Lanka and 37.81 per cent in Nepal, while the increase in India remained relatively modest.

"The difference is quite clear. While many developed nations saw fuel prices rise by more than 20 per cent and neighbouring countries by over 35 per cent, India kept the increase at around five per cent," Puri said.

He attributed this to the government's focus on ensuring stable fuel supplies, maintaining price stability and expanding refining capacity. India's refining capacity is expected to increase by 9-10 million metric tonnes annually, he added.

Rejecting claims that India lacks adequate strategic oil reserves, Puri said energy security should not be assessed solely on the basis of underground Strategic Petroleum Reserves (SPR).

"India has 24 refineries and 22 petroleum ports. Each refinery has its own stockpiles, and every port has storage facilities along with regular arrivals and departures. Combined with our SPR, India has stocks equivalent to about 76 to 80 days of consumption," he said.

Puri said India successfully managed fuel supplies during a four-month period when global shipping routes were affected by geopolitical tensions. During that period, the country maintained reserves equivalent to around 60 days of crude oil, 60 days of natural gas and 45 days of LPG consumption.

He said nearly 30 crude oil and LPG carriers were stranded near the Strait of Hormuz because of regional tensions.

"I would like to extend my gratitude to the Ministries of Petroleum and Natural Gas, External Affairs and Shipping, the Indian Navy, our embassies and other agencies. Through constant coordination, they ensured that 12 LPG carriers were able to sail safely," he said.

Puri said the government's approach during the global energy crisis has been to balance affordability, energy security and infrastructure development while protecting Indian consumers from the sharp fuel price increases seen in many other countries.

Govt fast-tracks

The proposed strategic sale of IDBI Bank also remains on the agenda. Although an earlier attempt to sell the government's stake did not succeed, efforts are underway to speed up the process and invite fresh bids.

The renewed push comes as the government faces the possibility of spending exceeding Budget estimates because of rising energy and fertiliser import costs linked to the West Asia crisis. The pressure is also being compounded by concerns over crude oil prices and the possible impact of El Nino on the monsoon.

Official accounts show that the fiscal deficit reached more than Rs 1.62 lakh crore, or 9.6 per cent of the FY27 Budget target, during the first two months of the financial year. By the end of May, net tax revenues had reached 12.1 per cent of the annual target, while miscellaneous capital receipts stood at 17 per cent. Revenue expenditure had touched 15.3 per cent of the full-year estimate and capital expenditure had reached 20.5 per cent.

Meeting revenue targets is expected to play an important role in managing fiscal pressures, including a likely doubling of the fertiliser subsidy bill to around Rs 3 lakh crore and higher crude oil import costs. The government has set a fiscal deficit target of 4.3 per cent for FY27.

Separate disinvestment targets have not been specified since the Revised Estimates for FY2023-24. Instead, receipts are now grouped under Miscellaneous Capital Receipts, which include proceeds from equity investment management and public asset monetisation. These were pegged at Rs 30,000 crore for RE 2023-24, Rs 33,000 crore for RE 2024-25, Rs 33,837 crore for RE 2025-26 and Rs 80,000 crore in the FY27 Budget.

Past collections have been mixed. Against revised estimates of Rs 78,000 crore in 2021-22 and Rs 50,000 crore in 2022-23, the government realised Rs 13,534 crore and Rs 35,294 crore, respectively. Earlier, it had raised Rs 50,300 crore against a revised estimate of Rs 65,000 crore in 2019-20 and Rs 32,886 crore against Rs 32,000 crore in 2020-21.

Seven workers

Seven people died on the spot," Girish told reporters.

He said five injured workers were receiving treatment and were out of danger, while four other labourers at the site escaped without injuries.

"It is very obvious that there was negligence due to which seven people lost their lives," Girish said.

Earlier in the day, Yeshwanthpur MLA and former minister S T Somashekar had claimed that another injured worker had died in hospital, taking the toll to eight. However, police later confirmed that the death toll remained at seven.

The force of the rockfall caused extensive destruction at the quarry. Loading vehicles were completely mangled, while a tractor at the site was shattered into pieces, reflecting the severity of the impact.

An official from the Mines and Geology Department, Rangappa, said the quarry owner had agreed to pay compensation of Rs 10 lakh to the families of each deceased worker and Rs 5 lakh to each injured labourer.

Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar expressed grief over the deaths and said the government would introduce fresh guidelines for quarrying operations across the state. "We will issue fresh guidelines for quarrying activities across the state. I will ensure that no such incident occurs again," he said.

The chief minister added that officials had been directed to visit the site and submit a detailed report. According to the preliminary findings, the tragedy was not caused by blasting but appeared to be linked to soil erosion. He also said compensation would be provided to the affected families but added that the immediate priority was to prevent such accidents from recurring.

Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara said the government would examine how quarrying permissions were being granted and take action if any lapses were found. He also raised concerns about illegal quarrying activities in the state.

Union Minister H D Kumaraswamy alleged that a powerful lobby involved in quarrying was prioritising profits over workers' safety and called for strict measures to prevent similar incidents.

Board exam

on coaching centres, multiple attempts and a gradual shift towards adaptive on-demand computer-based tests," a source said.

At present, admissions to medical and engineering courses are determined by entrance examination scores, while students must secure the required qualifying marks in board examinations to become eligible for these tests.

The proposals are being examined by the Ministry of Education's nine-member committee, formed by the Ministry of Education last year to study students' reliance on coaching institutes, the growth of dummy schools and fairness in high-stakes entrance examinations. The panel is expected to submit its final report to the government in the coming weeks. It has also recommended bringing entrance tests closer to school syllabi.

Govt brings stem cell

cell treatments, are increasingly being used to treat blood cancers such as leukaemia and lymphoma. Gene therapeutic products, including gene replacement and gene editing therapies, are being developed and used for genetic disorders as well as several types of cancers.

The amended rules also cover xenografts, which are products derived from animal tissues. These include heart valves that can be transplanted into humans and are commonly used in cardiology and orthopaedics.

The ministry said these technologies are highly complex, specialised and rapidly evolving, making stronger regulatory scrutiny necessary to ensure patient safety.

"The inclusion of these products under the CLAA framework will facilitate a system of joint oversight by the central and state licensing authorities, thereby ensuring uniformity in regulatory standards across the country," the ministry said in a statement.

It added that the amendment will strengthen regulatory standards for emerging medical technologies while aligning India's regulatory framework with scientific advances and global best practices.

The ministry said the move reflects the government's commitment to protecting public health while supporting innovation and enabling faster adoption of new technologies in the healthcare and life sciences sectors.

'Methyl Isocyanate of Law'

The verdict said courts must maintain complete integrity in the decision-making process and warned that citing AI-generated precedents without verification amounts to professional misconduct. "It is necessary for Courts to adopt a zero-tolerance mode for producing, citing or using AI-generated precedents without verification. It is a misconduct on the part of an advocate to cite such judgments without verification," the bench said.

The judges added that it would be an equally serious lapse if a court itself relied on fake or hallucinated AI-generated material. "We have no hesitation in declaring that such a decision is no decision in the eyes of the law, irrespective of whether such material had a direct or indirect bearing on the decision-making. Such decisions are to be set aside even if an iota of fake or hallucinated material enters the decision-making process, as it would violate the sanctity of adjudication," the ruling said.

The court reiterated "zero tolerance" for both the Bar and the Bench in citing, referring to or relying on fabricated material, while making it clear that the judgment does not restrict the legitimate use of artificial intelligence. "Our judgment shall have no bearing on the rightful use of AI, but on the presentation or reliance on fake or hallucinated material as if it were a court precedent," it said.

Calling for accountability, the bench observed that merely prohibiting such conduct would not be enough. It directed the Bar Council of India (BCI) to constitute a committee to examine instances of advocates submitting fake or hallucinated material before courts as legal precedents. The committee has been asked to deliberate on the issue with seriousness, formulate guiding principles to prevent such incidents and prescribe disciplinary action for violations.

During the hearing, Jammu and Kashmir Bank filed an affidavit stating that its counsel had not cited the fabricated cases and that the NCLT had obtained them through its "own research." However, the Supreme Court held that the source of the error did not lessen the damage caused to the rule of law.

The bench pointed out that the tribunal had relied on entirely fictitious citations, including ICICI Bank Ltd vs Urban Infrastructure Real Estate Ltd (2019) 16 SCC 528 and Sarbjit Singh vs Union Bank of India (2022) 7 SCC 464, besides attributing fabricated paragraphs to genuine judgments.

Stressing that technology should remain an aid and not replace judicial responsibility, the court said, "More than the inevitable consequence of setting aside such judgments, what is significant for our decision-making is our resolve to adopt AI technology in aid of adjudication, while at the same time asserting and declaring total and absolute control over adjudication, with a human in the loop at every stage."

TRUST GENERAL SECRETARY SAYS HE MAY NOT 'CONTINUE'

Amid Ram Mandir row, exit hint from Champat Rai as legal heat mounts

OUR CORRESPONDENT

AYODHYA: Ahead of a key meeting of the Ram temple trust next week, its former chief Champat Rai has indicated he won't continue with the "stigma" in the wake of the donation embezzlement controversy even as a priest in Ayodhya on Thursday accused him and "his gang" of illegally grabbing control of the shrine through forged documents.

A call on Rai and another Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust member Anil Mishra, who have both resigned from their posts, is likely to be taken by a two-thirds majority at the meeting on July 6, sources said.

They also said Rai has told his close associates that his "service in Ayodhya is complete" and that he will not continue with the "stigma".

According to the sources, Rai, who is currently in seclusion, said that his trust has been "betrayed". However, he did not specify.

Monday's meeting is also expected to deliberate on key issues concerning the trust management particularly in light of the recommendations of the Special Investigation Team (SIT) formed by the Uttar Pradesh government last month to look into the allegations of embezzlement.

The participation of trust chairman Mahant Nritya Gopal Das, 89, is uncertain as he is still in hospital with urinary tract infection and breathing difficulties.

Lawyers protest

The alleged embezzlement of donations also triggered fresh political and legal heat on Thursday, with a large number of lawyers taking to the streets in Ayodhya and demanding criminal action against senior office-bearers of the Trust.

The protesting advocates raised slogans against Rai, trustee Mishra and office-bearer Gopal Rao, and demanded that an FIR be lodged against them over the handling of the donation counting process and the alleged irregularities that have come to light.

The lawyers assembled around noon and marched towards the Ram Janmabhoomi police station. However, police stopped the protesters near the Civil Lines police outpost, preventing them from proceeding further.

A delegation of advocates later reached the Ram Janmabhoomi police station and submitted a written complaint seeking registration of a case against four persons, including the three trust functionaries. Police officials accepted the complaint and handed over an acknowledgement receipt to the delegation.

In another development, the Ayodhya Development Authority (ADA) has issued a notice to Supriya Mishra, wife of arrested accused Lavkush Mishra, over the construction of a luxury house allegedly being built in her name.


Lawyers of the Faizabad Bar Association submit a police complaint at the Ram Janam Bhoomi Police Station, in Ayodhya, on Thursday PTI

Highlights

- » A call on Rai and another Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust member Anil Mishra, who have both resigned from their posts, is likely to be taken by a two-thirds majority at the meeting on July 6, sources said
- » A delegation of advocates later reached the Ram Janmabhoomi police station and submitted a written complaint seeking registration of a case against four persons

Congress hints at 50-50 seat-sharing pact with SP in UP

'Will go into the elections with equality and respect'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LUCKNOW: Newly-appointed Uttar Pradesh Congress in-charge Rajendra Pal Gautam on Wednesday hinted at an equal seat-sharing arrangement with the Samajwadi Party for the 2027 Uttar Pradesh assembly elections.

Addressing his first press conference as in-charge of the party here, Gautam said, "We will go into the elections with equality and respect."

The remarks assume significance as the Congress and the Samajwadi Party had contested the 2024 Lok Sabha elections together as constituents of the INDIA bloc in Uttar Pradesh, winning 43 seats and limiting the BJP to 33 seats. This included the key Ayodhya Lok Sabha seat where the SP's Awadhesh Prasad became the first Dalit to win the key seat.

Back in 2024, the SP had won 37 seats while the Congress was victorious on six seats to limit the BJP's advance. "Of course, we have always shown a big heart. We are the bigger party nationally and we seek equality and respect (in the alliance)," Gautam said, replying to media queries.

> 'If the Congress is not given its due respect, it would amount to giving the BJP a walkover'

He said that only by giving the Congress its due respect can a winning atmosphere be created. "In the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, we were the elder brother, which is why we (INDIA bloc) won more seats. Regional parties no longer have the capacity to take on and defeat the BJP. Across the country, only Rahul Gandhi is fighting the BJP," Gautam said.

He also said that if the Congress is not given its due respect within the alliance, it would amount to giving the BJP a "walkover".

SP chief Akhilesh Yadav has also indicated that the alliance is likely to continue

A prominent Dalit leader who heads the Congress' Scheduled Caste Department at the national level, Gautam said the party would strengthen its organisation across UP within a month. He also said the party would fight to protect the Constitution, accusing the BJP of spreading hatred against Dalits, backward classes and minorities. He alleged that the Centre and the UP government had failed to curb examination paper leaks and provide adequate government jobs.

Attacking the BJP and the RSS, Gautam alleged "hate Dalits and tribals" and claimed that PM Narendra Modi did not invite the then president Ram Nath Kovind for the Ram temple foundation ceremony and President Droupadi Murmu for the temple inauguration because they belonged to Dalit and tribal communities.

Kejriwal questions govt over Ram temple donations embezzlement case

NEW DELHI: AAP convener Arvind Kejriwal on Thursday sought answers from Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the alleged Ram temple donations embezzlement case in Ayodhya, claiming only "pawns" were arrested in the matter and "powerful" persons involved in it were being protected.

Addressing a press conference, Kejriwal charged that there was a lot of corruption involved in the purchase of land and the construction of the temple as well as donations offered by devotees. "It cannot be accepted that all this was going on and the prime minister was unaware of it," he said.

The Ram Mandir Trust office bearers were handpicked by the prime minister himself. A home ministry officer is also part of the Trust, he said, questioning why the prime minister "did not act to stop the theft".

"They are hoodwinking us with the arrest of the eight persons; the real people (culprits) are someone else. These eight are merely pawns. I want to ask the PM whom he is saving and why," he said.

Kejriwal also trained guns at UP Chief Minister Adityanath, saying why he was not using bulldozers to demolish the houses of those who allegedly committed theft of donations and hurt the sentiments of crores of people.

The AAP convenor alleged that private persons sold land worth Rs 14 crore for Rs 95 crore to the temple Trust, and there were claims of commission taken in construction work. A Special Investigation Team (SIT) constituted by the Uttar Pradesh government submitted its preliminary findings on June 23, following which an FIR was registered on June 25 and eight persons associated with the temple's donation-counting process were arrested.

AAP, BJP target Cong over Punjab poll panels

CHANDIGARH: Ruling party AAP and the BJP on Thursday suggested that all was not well within the Punjab Congress following the announcement of its various committees for the 2027 Assembly polls.

They even took a jibe, saying the ambitions of a few Punjab Congress leaders have been "buried deep in soil."

The Congress on Wednesday decided to continue with Amrinder Singh Raja Warring as the state unit president. At the same time, it appointed former Punjab chief minister and Jalandhar MP Charanjit Singh Channi as chairperson of the campaign committee.

The party also did not make any change in the position of the leader of opposition in the Punjab Vidhan Sabha, which is currently held by senior party leader and Qadian MLA Partap Singh Bajwa.

Gurdaspur MP and former deputy chief minister Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa has been appointed as chairperson of the core committee.

In a bid to check factionalism, the party accommodated several party leaders in different committees for the upcoming 2027 Punjab assembly polls.

Channi and Randhawa were seen as contenders for the post of Punjab Congress president.

Reacting to the appointments, AAP leader and Cabinet minister Harjot Singh Bains on Thursday claimed that Congress leaders Channi and Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa have issued no statement or any message thanking the party leadership for their appointments.

"Ambition buried deep in soil. Channi Saab, Randhawa Saab, 'no statement, no celebration, no thanks. Seems like. 'Dil ke armaan, aansuon mein beh gaye' (desires of heart washed away in tears), for them," Bains said in a post on X.

"2027 Bhagwant Mann Once More," Bains further said.

Union Minister Ravneet Singh Bittu, while reacting to the Punjab Congress organisational list, said that the Congress has distributed "lollipops" to everyone in the party instead of building a serious and effective organisation. MPOST

Key Points

- » AAP leader and Cabinet minister Harjot Singh Bains on Thursday claimed that Congress leaders Channi and Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa have issued no statement or any message thanking the party leadership for their appointments
- » It is surprising that even senior leaders who are members of the AICC and the Congress Working Committee (CWC) have been accommodated as chairpersons of various committees, said Bittu in a statement

EC announces July 30 bypolls for three states

NEW DELHI: The Election Commission on Thursday announced the schedule for bypolls to three assembly constituencies in Bihar, Madhya Pradesh and Gujarat, with polling slated for July 30.

The bypolls will be held in Bankipur in Bihar, Datia in Madhya Pradesh and Manjalpur in Gujarat, the Commission said.

The vacancies arose following the resignation of BJP president Nitin Nabin as an MLA in Bihar, the disqualification of Madhya Pradesh Congress legislator Rajendra Bharti after his conviction in a fraud case, and the death of Gujarat BJP MLA Yogeshbhai Narandas Patel.

According to the schedule, the gazette notification for the bypolls will be issued on July 6, while July 13 is the last date for filing nominations. Scrutiny of nomination papers will be held on July 14 and the last date for withdrawal of candidature is July 16. Counting will be held on August 3.

The Model Code of Conduct has come into force with immediate effect in the districts where the whole or part of the assembly constituencies going to the polls are situated, the commission said.

The EC said EVMs and VVPATs will be used at all polling stations. It also reiterated that candidates with criminal antecedents and the political parties nominating them will have to publish details of such antecedents in newspapers, television channels and on their official websites in accordance with Supreme Court directions. MPOST

Centre notifies three sets of rules under VB-G RAM G Act

NEW DELHI: The Centre has notified three sets of rules under the VB-G RAM G Act, laying down the framework for the transition from MGNREGS, payment of wages and unemployment allowance, and expenditure beyond the Centre's normative allocation, government sources said.

The rules, notified by the Ministry of Rural Development through separate Gazette notifications dated July 1, came into force from the date of their publication. The draft rules were issued in May and the government had invited feedback on them.

The Transitional Provisions Rules provide for an orderly migration from the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (MGNREGS) to the new employment guarantee framework -- Viksit Bharat-"Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) Act, 2025.

They require state governments to verify all liabilities under MGNREGS existing up to June 30, settle admissible dues and submit audited utilisation certificates within 180 days, extendable by another 90 days by the Centre for recorded reasons.

The Centre will continue fund support for liabilities existing up to June 30, while allowing interim allocations to states until the final rules governing normative allocation are framed.

The rules also provide that the ongoing MGNREGS works will continue under the new Act, while e-KYC-verified MGNREGS job cards will remain valid until states issue new Gramin Rozgar Guarantee Cards.

Existing employment records, physical and digital records and assets created under MGNREGS will also be transferred and preserved during the transition. AGENCIES

'Show restraint': Delhi HC tells scribe Anjana Om Kashyap, Khan Sir

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Thursday told TV Today Network Ltd and its managing editor Anjana Om Kashyap to refrain from making statements against Faisal Khan, popularly known as 'Khan Sir', and also asked the educator to remove his post on the journalist's child.

Justice Tushar Rao Gedela, while referring to mediation of Kashyap and the news network's case against Khan Sir and other teachers over the publication of alleged defamatory social media posts, underscored that "restraint" has to be shown by both sides.

Calling for an amicable settlement, the court asked the defendants to consider removing "unparliamentary" references in their posts.

> Asks defendants to consider removing "unparliamentary" references in posts

Besides Khan Sir, the lawsuit has named Abhinay Maths founder Abhinay Sharma, ICS coaching co-founder Babita Tyagi and Naiya Paar Education's Arvind Bhadauriya as defendants. The plaintiffs' counsel submitted that Khan Sir has revealed information on social media on where Kashyap's children are studying and that she was "getting threats".

"They (plaintiffs) will refrain. You (Khan Sir) take down the disclosure about the child. Try and talk to them (defendants) and (see that) part where some words have been used if they can be expunged," the court told the lawyers."Restraint has to be shown by both. You (plaintiff's counsel) ensure your client slows down. And you (Khan Sir) stop the disclosure (on children). This is not an issue that should be coming to court. When you are teaching youngsters, it should not become a part of you, correct?" the court orally added.

The counsel for the plaintiffs and Khan Sir gave an assurance that they would exercise restraint. MPOST

After two decades, Rabri Devi leaves government bungalow

PATNA: Former Bihar chief minister Rabri Devi on Thursday shifted to her own house, giving up the government bungalow that had been her residence as the camp office of the RJD, headed by her husband Lalu Prasad, for nearly two decades.

The development is being seen as indicative of a diminution in clout of the proverbial first family of the opposition party, which was on good terms with the ruling dispensation until it was headed by JD(U) president Nitish Kumar.

Rabri Devi had been allotted 10, Circular Road, situated right across the street from the chief minister's residence and a stone's throw from the Governor's House, by the previous Nitish Kumar government, shortly after she lost power in the 2005 assembly polls.

She moved to her private house in Kautilya Nagar, situated about 2 km away, under pressure from the BJP administration headed by Samrat Choudhary, which has allotted 10, Circular Road to party leader and minister Nand Kishor Ram. She had been first asked to vacate the house in November last year when the Nitish Kumar government ordered that 10, Circular Road shall be "designated as the deputy CM's residence" and the RJD leader was allotted another bungalow in her capacity as the leader of the opposition in the state legislative council.

However, Rabri Devi refused to move to 39, Hardinge Road, which is not as spacious as 10, Circular Road, in addition to being perceived as "unlucky" since the political fortunes of all past occupants took a nosedive after staying there. AGENCIES


A vehicle carrying household goods leaves the official residence of Rabri Devi PTI

Who is Avinash Shukla? Teacher at centre of Ram Temple row after Rs 20 lakh recovery

Investigators are probing how the teacher amassed so much wealth in months

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The recovery of Rs 20 lakh in cash, foreign currency and jewellery from the house of a primary school teacher arrested in the alleged Ram Temple donation theft case has raised fresh questions over the functioning of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust and the handling of the investigation.

At the centre of the controversy is Avinash Shukla, an accused in the case who worked in the temple's donation counting section. Investigators are now trying to establish how a man with a modest income allegedly amassed such wealth in a matter of months.

The recovery has also put the spotlight on another troubling issue. According to witnesses and sources, irregularities in donation counting were detected on June 5 and Avinash was removed from duty the same day. However, an FIR was registered only on June 7, hours after Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav raised the issue on social media.

The two-day delay has become one of the key questions before the Special Investigation Team (SIT).

People associated with the Shyam Sadhan Yog Kendra in Ayodhya said Avinash came from a modest background and worked as a primary school teacher with a monthly salary of around Rs 14,000-15,000. Before joining the Ram Temple's counting section in March this year, he reportedly sold water near Hanuman Gufa.

Police allegedly recovered Rs 20 lakh in cash from his residence, the highest recovery among the eight accused arrested in the case.

A seizure memo that surfaced on Wednesday showed that apart from cash, investigators seized 1,121 US dollars, silver ornaments weighing 159.54 grams, an eight-gram gold chain and a gold ring weighing 3.44 grams.

A key witness, sevadar Sundarlal, claimed that on June 5, four policemen and some persons linked to the trust brought Avinash to his room at the Shyam Sadhan Yog Kendra in Kaushalpuri. According to him, a trunk was opened using a key and two bags were taken out before everyone present was asked to leave. He later learnt that around Rs 20 lakh had been recovered from Avinash.

Yoga instructor Seema Tiwari said Avinash's brother, Abhishek Shukla, had been associated with the centre for nearly a decade and had introduced Avinash to the institution about one-and-a-half years ago. She claimed Abhishek had links with people associated with the temple, which may have helped Avinash secure a job in the donation counting section. The controversy has also reached the top leadership of the RSS.

Sources said eastern Uttar Pradesh regional pracharak Anil Kumar recently spent three days in Ayodhya and prepared a report on the temple's management and the donation theft controversy, which has been submitted to RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat. A meeting of the 15-member Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust is scheduled on July 6. Sources said discussions are underway on restructuring the trust, increasing the representation of saints and reviewing the powers and responsibilities of certain office-bearers.

SIT visits Ram Temple again

AYODHYA: The SIT on Thursday visited the Ram Temple complex for the second time as part of its investigation into the alleged embezzlement of donations. The team reached the temple around 3 pm and examined various records and arrangements related to the counting and storage of offerings made by devotees. The SIT had earlier camped in Ayodhya between June 15 and June 20 and carried out an extensive inquiry into the case. MPOST

Congress questions timing of Datia bypoll

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

BHOPAL: Newly-appointed Uttar Pradesh Congress in-charge Rajendra Pal Gautam on Wednesday hinted at an equal seat-sharing arrangement with the Samajwadi Party for the 2027 Uttar Pradesh assembly elections.

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Thursday announced that the by-election to the Datia Assembly constituency in Madhya Pradesh will be held on July 30 following the disqualification of Congress MLA Rajendra Bharti after his conviction in a bank fraud case.

According to the ECI, the Gazette Notification for the by-election will be issued on 6 July, with July 13 fixed as the last date for filing nominations. Counting of votes will take place on August 3.

The announcement immediately triggered a political war of words between the ruling BJP and the opposition Congress. Leader of Opposition Umang Singhar accused the ECI of acting with undue haste in announcing the Datia bypoll, citing the pending disqualification proceedings against Bina MLA Nirmala Sapre, who was elected on a Congress ticket in 2023 but later joined the BJP. Her disqualification petition is pending before the Madhya Pradesh High Court.

Questioning the ECI's timing, Singhar said Sapre's disqualification case had remained pending for nearly two years, while the Datia by-poll was announced without delay. Alleging political motives behind Bharti's disqualification, he expressed confidence that the Congress would retain the seat. The Datia constituency carries considerable political significance as Bharti had defeated BJP heavyweight and then State Home Minister Narottam Mishra in the 2023 Assembly elections.

Bharti lost his Assembly membership after a Delhi MP-MLA court sentenced him to three years' imprisonment in a cooperative bank cheating case. He has challenged the conviction in the Delhi High Court, where his plea for a stay is scheduled to be heard on July 8.

Rejecting the Congress charge, Cabinet Minister Kailash Vijayvargiya said the ECI was duty-bound to fill the vacant seat and the BJP would announce its candidate soon.

GULF OF ADEN

INS Trikand thwarts piracy bid on foreign-flagged merchant ship

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Indian Navy stealth frigate INS Trikand t,hwarted a piracy attempt on a foreign-flagged merchant vessel, carrying 21 crew members including one Indian national, in the Gulf of Aden, officials said on Thursday.

The piracy incident was reported in coordination with the Information Fusion Centre - Indian Ocean Region (IFC-IOR) based in Gurugram, a spokesperson of the India Navy said. MV Golden Arsenal, a St. Vincent and the Grenadines-flagged bulk carrier, reported an attempted pirate attack approximately 300 nautical miles east-northeast of Djibouti on July 1, the official said.

Indian Naval Ship Trikand, a mission-deployed stealth frigate of the Indian Navy operating in the Gulf of Aden, responded swiftly to the piracy attempt on the vessel. "The merchant vessel, carrying 21 crew members, including one Indian national, reported damage to the bridge superstructure and adjoining compartments. The crew had taken shelter in the vessel's citadel and were reported safe," the spokesperson said.

On Thursday morning, a boarding team from INS Trikand embarked MV Golden Arsenal to sanitise the vessel and assess the situation.

"Following a thorough search, no suspicious personnel were found onboard. The crew subsequently exited the citadel safely and, along with Indian Navy personnel, commenced an assessment of the vessel's condition," the official said.

To augment the operation, a P-8I Maritime Patrol Aircraft of the Indian Navy was deployed to undertake aerial surveillance and reconnaissance in the area, enhancing maritime domain awareness and supporting the anti-piracy response, the spokesperson said.

"With the vessel sanitised and the immediate threat neutralised, anti-piracy operations by INS Trikand have concluded. And, MV Golden Arsenal has since resumed her onward voyage," the official said.

The Indian Navy remains committed to safeguarding merchant shipping, countering piracy and ensuring the safety and security of all seafarers in the Indian Ocean Region, irrespective of nationality, as part of its continued commitment to maritime security in the region.

Indian Naval Ship Trikand operating in the Gulf of Aden, responds to a piracy attempt on MV Golden Arsenal PTI

HIGHLIGHTS

- The piracy incident was reported in coordination with the Information Fusion Centre - Indian Ocean Region (IFC-IOR) based in Gurugram
- MV Golden Arsenal, a St. Vincent and the Grenadines-flagged bulk carrier, reported an attempted pirate attack approximately 300 nautical miles east-northeast of Djibouti on July 1
- Indian Naval Ship Trikand, a mission-deployed stealth frigate of the Indian Navy operating in the Gulf of Aden, responded swiftly to the piracy attempt on the vessel
- To augment the operation, a P-8I Maritime Patrol Aircraft of the Indian Navy was deployed to undertake aerial surveillance and reconnaissance in the area, enhancing maritime domain awareness and supporting the anti-piracy response

YATRIS WELCOMED WITH FLOWER PETALS IN VALLEY

Amarnath Yatra: 1st batch of 4,822 pilgrims proceeds towards Baltal & Pahalgam camps

MPOST BUREAU

SRINAGAR: The first batch of pilgrims for the annual Amarnath Yatra received a warm welcome as they reached the Kashmir valley on Thursday, officials said.

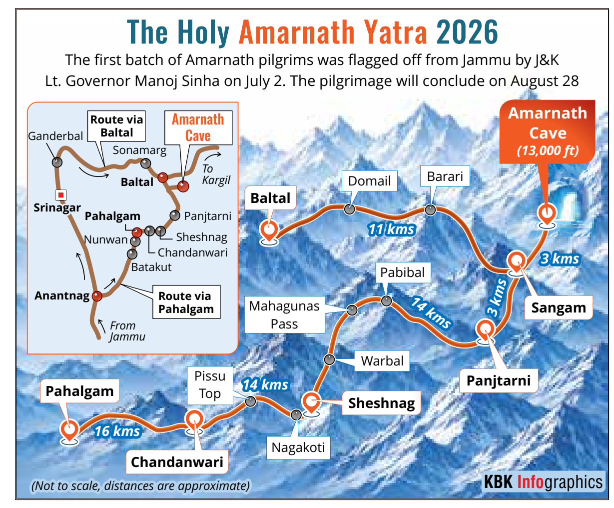
The batch of 4,822 pilgrims was flagged off earlier in the day by Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha from the Bhagwati Nagar Yatri Niwas in Jammu.

As the convoy entered the Valley through the Navyug Tunnel in Qazigund area of south Kashmir's Kulgam district under tight multi-tier security cover, they received a rousing welcome, officials said.

Police and civil administration officials, including the IG CRPF (Inspector General in Central Reserve Police Force) and DIG South Kashmir Range Javid Iqbal Matoo, greeted the pilgrims with garlands, flower bouquets and petals.

The convoy later proceeded separately towards the Baltal and Pahalgam base camps, from where pilgrims will begin the onward journey early Friday to the 3,880-metre-high Amarnath cave shrine.

Meanwhile, Jammu and Kashmir Police chief Nalin Prabhat reviewed security and facilitation arrangements for the Amarnath Yatra at Pahalgam on Thursday.



The 57-day pilgrimage to the 3,880-metre-high Amarnath cave shrine is scheduled to begin on July 3 simultaneously via the traditional 48-km Nunwan-Pahalgam route in the Anantnag district and the shorter but steeper 14-km Baltal route in the Ganderbal district. The yatra will conclude on August 28.

Prabhat, the Director General of Police, visited the Nunwan Frisking Point at Pahalgam to review the security and facilitation arrangements for the smooth and safe conduct of the ongoing Shri Amarnath Ji Yatra, a police spokesperson said. The DGP conducted a comprehensive inspection of the frisking point, assessing security measures, access control mechanisms, personnel deployment, and the overall arrangements made for the convenience and safety of the pilgrims.

Haryana CEO asks parties to support SIR exercise

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Electoral Officer A. Sreenivas on Thursday asked all recognised national and state political parties to organise meetings between their booth level agents and booth level officers to ensure the smooth conduct of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

Chairing a meeting with party representatives, he said election authorities should be informed in advance of such meetings, which should be videographed and photographed.

Sreenivas said the revision drive will continue till July 14 and the final electoral rolls will be published on September 22. BLOs have been directed to make at least three visits to households where enumeration forms are pending and carry blank Form-6 applications to facilitate enrolment of eligible new voters. MPOST

Punjab Cabinet revises land acquisition policy

CHANDIGARH: The Punjab Cabinet, chaired by Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann, on Wednesday approved amendments to the state's Land Acquisition and Oustee Policy, enhancing benefits for landowners and introducing several new relief measures.

According to the Chief Minister's Office, the revised policy increases commercial plot entitlement under the residential and commercial category from 200 square yards to 210 square yards per acre, while the residential entitlement remains unchanged at 1,000 square yards per acre. Landowners opting only for residential plots will now receive 1,630 square yards per acre, up from 1,600 square yards. For commercial-category projects, commercial entitlement has been raised from 800 square yards to 840 square yards per acre. The Cabinet also revised the Oustee Policy, under which landowners whose one acre of land is acquired will be entitled to a 200-square-yard plot. Those losing more than one acre and up to 2.5 acres will receive a 300-square-yard plot, while those with over 2.5 acres acquired will be eligible for a 500-square-yard plot.

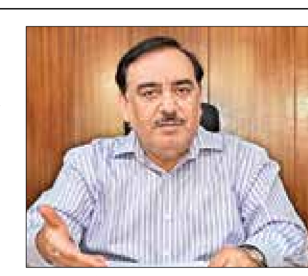
Among other measures, the Cabinet approved a Letter of Intent provision for small farmers and extended the validity of the Sahuliyat Certificate from two years to four years. Original landowners allotted developed plots will be exempt from stamp duty and registration charges or can avail the exemption while purchasing land elsewhere. MPOST

AI can improve infrastructure quality: Haryana QAA chairman

SWATI MAHAJAN

CHANDIGARH: Considering the deficiencies flagged by the Haryana Quality Assurance Authority (QAA) across various departments, it appears that adherence to manuals, protocols and project deadlines remains a major challenge in the execution of government projects. Challenging conditions in government offices, multiple responsibilities and impractical timelines are among the primary factors hindering the efficient completion of public works.

QAA chairman Rajeev Arora said gaps have been found in projects executed by departments dealing with public health, power, roads and buildings. He believes the use



of artificial intelligence (AI) can significantly improve project monitoring, ensure timely completion and strengthen compliance with prescribed procedures.

A review by the statutory body found that sewerage, stormwater drainage and water supply networks were often not planned or designed in accordance with technical manuals, prescribed design criteria, hydraulic parameters and material specifications. In road projects, the QAA observed that daily progress reports were not being properly scrutinised by officers and recommended strict action against laxity. It also stressed that detailed drainage plans should be incorporated into project reports to ensure effective stormwater management.

The authority further noted that detailed construction drawings were frequently not prepared or approved before the execution of water supply and sewerage pipeline works.

Speaking to **Millennium Post**, Arora said the QAA could serve as a single-window knowledge and advisory partner for engineering departments, helping improve the quality of public infrastructure.

Government committed to accelerate Haryana's growth: CM

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Thursday asserted that the state would play a leading role in achieving the vision of Viksit Bharat-2047, highlighting rapid industrial growth, infrastructure expansion and investor-friendly policies.

Addressing a programme in Gurugram, Saini said Haryana has emerged as one of the country's leading states and the government is committed to accelerating its development journey. He said the state government is taking youth, farmers, women and the poor along the path of progress through transparent and people-centric governance. The CM said Haryana's new Industrial Policy was framed after extensive consultations with industry representatives and by studying best practices from across India and abroad. The policy aims to attract investments worth Rs 5 lakh crore. He noted that investment proposals worth Rs 1.10 lakh crore were received on the very day the policy was launched, reflecting growing investor confidence.

To facilitate investments, the government has strengthened the single-window clearance system to provide approvals within 14 to 15 days. Work has also begun on developing 10 new Industrial Model Townships (IMTs) across the state. Referring to his recent visit to Japan, Saini said Haryana received investment proposals worth thousands of crores and reiterated the government's commitment to creating world-class infrastructure and making the state a preferred investment destination.

He said industries employing Haryana's youth would now receive incentives of up to Rs 1 lakh per eligible employee, while those hiring persons with disabilities would get Rs 1.25 lakh. The government has also strengthened coordination between industries and Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs) to ensure skill development matches industry needs. MPOST

MoS Rai felicitates CAPF teams on successful Everest expeditions

NEW DELHI: Union Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai on Wednesday felicitated the Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP), Border Security Force (BSF) and National Security Guard (NSG) teams on their successful return from the Mount Everest Expedition-2026 and the BSF Mount Lhotse Expedition-2026 at a flag-in ceremony in the national capital.

The minister also laid the foundation stone for new NSG buildings and inaugurated newly commissioned ITBP infrastructure. Home Secretary Govind Mohan, Intelligence Bureau Director Mahesh Dixit, ITBP Director General Shatrujeet Kapur, NSG Director General B. Srinivasan, BSF Director General Praveen Kumar, senior officials and members of the

expedition teams attended the event.

Congratulating the climbers, Rai said hoisting the Tricolour atop the world's highest peak was a matter of pride for the entire nation. He praised the discipline, courage, professionalism and teamwork displayed by the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs), describing mountaineering as the ultimate test of leadership, decision-making and team spirit. He said the true measure of a successful expedition lay in ensuring the safe return of every climber and added that the CAPFs had once again demonstrated their capability.

Rai described this year's achievements as historic, highlighting ITBP's first all-women Mount Everest expedition, BSF's first all-women Mount Everest and Mount Lhotse expeditions, and NSG's maiden Mount Everest expedition. MPOST

Username row: Notices sent to Telegram, Signal

NEW DELHI: After sending a notice to WhatsApp, the IT Ministry has now sent a notice to Telegram and Signal, raising questions on their existing username feature and asking how the platforms are addressing concerns related to fraud and impersonation, according to a source.

Sources said that in the notice to Telegram, the government has asked the platform why it should be allowed to retain the username feature.

On Wednesday, the Centre issued a notice to Meta over the username feature on WhatsApp, citing concerns that it could materially increase online fraud, phishing, digital arrest scams, and impersonation attacks.

It had also directed WhatsApp to pause the feature until consultations on the issue are completed "to the satisfaction of the Government".

INSIGHT

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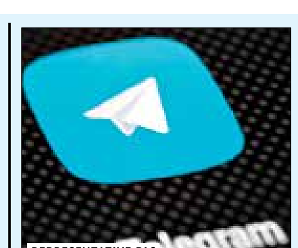


REPRESENTATIVE PIC

The government has now widened its scrutiny to other messaging platforms as well, sources said. They said that the IT ministry has also written to Telegram and Signal - which already have the username feature - and asked how concerns around fraud and impersonation are being addressed by them.

In its notice to WhatsApp, the government had expressed concern that the proposed username feature may "materially increase" cases of online fraud, phishing, digital arrest scams, and impersonation attacks by enabling bad actors to solicit and message victims.

Meta was asked to explain why action shouldn't be initiated under the IT Act and rules over WhatsApp's new feature that may increase cybercrimes.

The Centre also reminded Meta that WhatsApp, as a significant social media intermediary, was bound by due diligence obligations under the IT Act and rules.

WhatsApp defended the feature, citing built-in safeguards to prevent scams and impersonations and protect users. India is WhatsApp's largest market, and with more than 500 million users, it enjoys a far bigger user base here than Telegram.

Over the past month, Telegram has come under the regulatory lens in India over concerns related to fraud, impersonation and circulation of sensitive content. The government had imposed a ban on Telegram and its associated web services until June 22, citing the platform's failure to curb the circulation of leaked and fake NEET papers. AGENCIES

Syama Prasad Mookerjee: 'The man who saw India as one constitutional civilisation'

SUBHASH BARALA

In the life of a nation, some leaders are not merely remembered; they are rediscovered when history catches up with their questions. Syama Prasad Mookerjee belongs to that rare category of national figures whose life was brief, but whose ideas travelled far beyond his time.

Born in Calcutta on 6 July 1901, Mookerjee inherited scholarship, discipline and public purpose from his father, Sir Ashutosh Mookerjee, one of Bengal's great educationists. His early journey was marked not by political noise, but by intellectual rigour. He studied at Presidency College, became a barrister, and at only 33 became the youngest Vice-Chancellor of Calcutta University. Before he became a mass political figure, he was already an institution-builder.

That is what made his politics different. For Mookerjee, nationalism was not an emotional slogan alone. It was a constitutional, cultural and civilisational responsibility. He entered public life through the Bengal Legislative Council, representing the Calcutta University constituency, and later played a major role in Bengal's political life. He served as Finance Minister in Bengal and then, after Independence, joined India's first Union Cabinet as Minister for Industry and Supply.

He was not a man who treated office as an end in itself. When he believed that the direction of national policy was compromising India's interests, he chose principle over position. His resignation from the Union Cabinet was not an act of political convenience; it was a declaration that power without conviction is merely administration, not leadership.

Mookerjee's most enduring contribution came in 1951, when he founded the Bharatiya Jana Sangh and became its first National President. At a time when the Congress system dominated India's politics almost completely, he created a democratic nationalist alternative. In 1952, he was elected to the First Lok Sabha from Calcutta South East in Bengal. That old parliamentary constituency no longer exists in the same form; it was abolished before the 1957 parliamentary election. But its historical memory remains connected with the larger south Kolkata political landscape. In the recent West Bengal Assembly election, the BJP's victory in Bhabanipur under Suvendu Adhikari carried symbolic weight in this very political geography.

But Mookerjee must not be reduced to electoral nostalgia. His real legacy lies in the moral clarity with which he asked one foundational question: can one nation have two constitutional souls?

His call one nation, one Constitution, one flag, one head of state was not a narrow political formulation. It was a warning that constitutional exceptionalism, if left unresolved, could slowly weaken national integration. On Jammu and Kashmir, he did not argue as a partisan agitator; he argued as a constitutional nationalist. He believed that the rights, duties and dignity of Indian citizenship must flow uniformly to every citizen. The Lok Sabha Secretariat records his resolve in the words: "I will get you the Indian Constitution or lay down my life for it." He was arrested during his Jammu and Kashmir movement and died in Srinagar on 23 June 1953.

Decades later, when Article 370 was abrogated in 2019, India did more than change a constitutional provision. It addressed a historical contradiction that Mookerjee had identified with extraordinary foresight. The Government of India moved the resolution to make Article 370 inoperative in August 2019, and Parliament approved the resolution, paving the way for the full constitutional integration of Jammu and Kashmir with the Indian Union.

Yet, to understand Mookerjee only through Kashmir would be to read only one chapter of a much larger book. He was equally a thinker of education, industry, parliamentary opposition, Bengal's future and national reconstruction. His parliamentary interventions were sharp but constructive.

He understood that democracy needs not only a ruling party, but also an opposition with intellectual depth, national commitment and institutional seriousness.

That is why his life speaks powerfully to India today. We live in an era where development, identity, security and constitutional governance cannot be separated. A nation cannot become strong by forgetting its civilisational roots. Nor can it become modern by weakening its institutions. Mookerjee understood both truths at once.

He stood for cultural confidence without inferiority, constitutional unity without confusion, and democratic opposition without destructive politics. His nationalism was not defensive; it was constructive. His politics was not about dividing India into vote banks; it was about integrating India into one national destiny.

As we mark his birth anniversary, especially in the 125th year of his birth, India must remember him not merely as the founder of the Jana Sangh or as an ideological ancestor of the BJP. He must be remembered as a statesman who saw the Constitution as the spine of India's nationhood.

The most powerful tribute to Syama Prasad Mookerjee is not ritual remembrance. It is the commitment to build an India where every citizen enjoys equal constitutional dignity, where every region participates in national progress, where political power serves civilisational purpose, and where national unity is treated not as a slogan but as a sacred duty.

Mookerjee's life ended in 1953. His argument did not. It lives in the Constitution, in Parliament, in Jammu and Kashmir's integration, in Bengal's changing political consciousness, and in the larger aspiration of a confident Bharat.

History has vindicated him. The responsibility now is to fulfil him.

(The author is a Member of Parliament, Rajya Sabha, from Haryana)

'SUPER 100'

Khattar, Saini felicitate Hry students who cleared IIT-JEE

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Union Minister Manohar Lal Khattar and Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Thursday felicitated students from the state who qualified the IIT-JEE examination under the Super 100 Programme at a function here. Addressing the gathering, Saini congratulated the successful students and said their achievement reflected hard work, determination and the quality of education being provided under the Super 100 Programme.

He encouraged them to continue striving for excellence and contribute to nation-building. Khattar lauded the students for their success and appreciated the efforts of teachers, parents and the state government in guiding them.

He said such initiatives help talented students achieve their dreams and strengthen the country's future.

EDITORIAL

PARTNERS IN PROGRESS

Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi's visit to India marks far more than another ceremonial exchange between two friendly nations. It reflects the steady evolution of one of Asia's most stable and strategically significant partnerships at a time when the global order is undergoing profound change. In recent years, wars, disrupted supply chains, technological rivalries and geopolitical uncertainties have compelled nations to reassess both their economic priorities and security partnerships. Against this backdrop, India and Japan have unveiled a fresh set of initiatives spanning artificial intelligence, semiconductors, clean energy, defence cooperation, critical minerals and resilient supply chains. These are not isolated agreements but part of a broader vision to shape an Indo-Pacific that is secure, prosperous and rules-based. For India, Japan remains its most trusted development partner, having contributed significantly to transformative infrastructure projects ranging from metro rail systems to industrial corridors and the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail project. For Japan, India represents not merely a vast market but a democratic partner with growing economic strength, technological capabilities and strategic relevance. The summit therefore signals the beginning of a new phase in which both countries seek to move beyond traditional development cooperation towards jointly building the industries, technologies and institutions that will define the twenty-first century.

The importance of this partnership lies in its complementarity. Japan possesses advanced manufacturing expertise, cutting-edge research, financial strength and decades of industrial experience. India offers demographic advantage, a vibrant digital ecosystem, expanding manufacturing ambitions and one of the world's fastest-growing large economies. Together, they possess the ingredients necessary to create globally competitive value chains that are less vulnerable to geopolitical disruptions. This assumes greater significance as companies across the world seek to diversify production away from excessive dependence on single-country manufacturing networks. India's Production-Linked Incentive schemes, expanding electronics sector and improving logistics infrastructure make it an increasingly attractive destination for Japanese investment. Meanwhile, Japan's experience in precision engineering, robotics, automation and green technologies can significantly accelerate India's industrial transformation. The emphasis on cooperation in artificial intelligence, semiconductor ecosystems and critical minerals is particularly timely because these sectors will underpin economic competitiveness over the coming decades. Countries that successfully develop capabilities in these areas will enjoy greater technological sovereignty and stronger economic resilience. Rather than competing against each other, India and Japan are recognising that their comparative strengths can be combined to create mutual prosperity while contributing to global supply-chain stability.

Security cooperation has also emerged as an increasingly important pillar of bilateral ties. The Indo-Pacific today faces multiple challenges, including maritime disputes, strategic competition and growing concerns over economic coercion. India and Japan share an interest in ensuring that sea lanes remain open, international law is respected and regional stability is preserved. Their cooperation through the Quad, regular naval exercises and expanding defence dialogues demonstrates a convergence that extends well beyond diplomatic rhetoric. The latest understanding on defence co-development is particularly noteworthy because it moves the relationship from conventional defence procurement towards collaborative research, innovation and manufacturing. Such cooperation has the potential to strengthen indigenous defence capabilities in both countries while creating new opportunities for industrial collaboration. Equally important is the shared commitment to economic security, an area that has assumed unprecedented importance in recent years. Protecting critical infrastructure, securing semiconductor supplies, strengthening cyber resilience and ensuring access to strategic minerals are no longer purely economic concerns; they are now integral to national security. India and Japan have recognised this changing reality and are responding with a partnership that integrates economic growth with strategic resilience.

Despite impressive progress, however, considerable untapped potential remains. Bilateral trade continues to be modest when measured against the size of the two economies. Japanese investment in India has grown steadily but often encounters familiar challenges related to land acquisition, regulatory complexity, contract enforcement and project implementation. Addressing these bottlenecks will be essential if India wishes to attract larger volumes of high-quality manufacturing investment. At the same time, Japan must broaden its engagement beyond major infrastructure and automobile projects to include India's expanding start-up ecosystem, digital economy, biotechnology, education and advanced research. Greater collaboration between universities, research institutions and private enterprises can generate innovation that benefits both societies. People-to-people exchanges also deserve renewed attention. Educational partnerships, skill development programmes and greater mobility for students and professionals can deepen mutual understanding while addressing labour shortages in Japan and creating new opportunities for India's skilled workforce. The relationship will acquire greater depth when cooperation extends beyond governments and large corporations to include entrepreneurs, researchers, local governments and civil society institutions.

The significance of Prime Minister Takaichi's visit therefore lies not only in the announcements made today but in the direction they establish for the future. As India aspires to become a developed nation by 2047 and Japan seeks renewed economic dynamism amid demographic challenges, each country possesses capabilities the other increasingly requires. Together, they can build resilient supply chains, accelerate technological innovation, promote sustainable growth and contribute to a more balanced Indo-Pacific order. In an era when global partnerships are increasingly tested by uncertainty, the India-Japan relationship stands out because it is anchored in shared democratic values, mutual respect and complementary strengths. If both governments maintain the momentum generated by this visit, their partnership could emerge as one of the defining strategic relationships of Asia, delivering benefits not only to their own citizens but also to the wider region and the global economy.

ACADEMIC FUTURE

Saving India's Universities

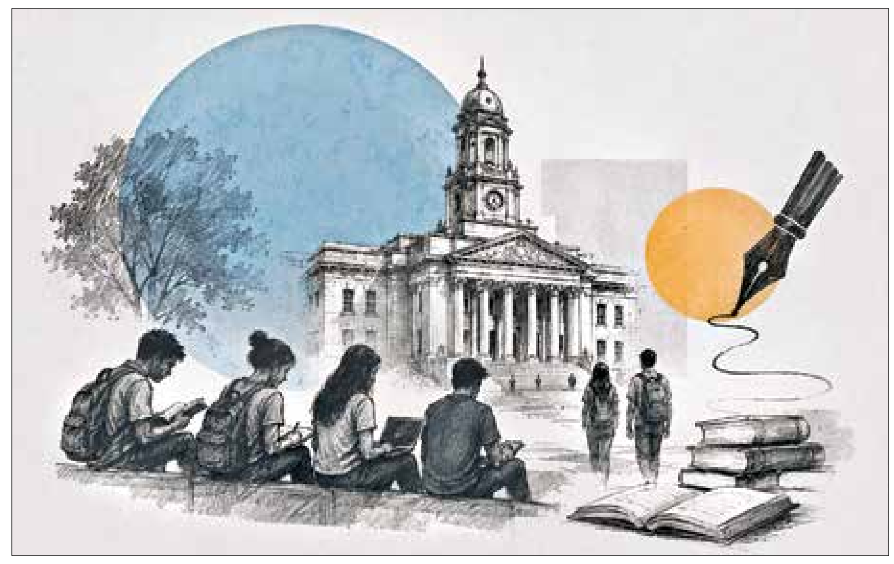
As India pursues the Vikshit Bharat 2047 vision, safeguarding university autonomy and reversing poor higher education participation have become urgent national priorities

CHANDRA BHUSHAN SHARMA

THE WRITER IS THE VICE-CHANCELLOR OF VINOBA BHAVE UNIVERSITY, HAZARIBAG, JHARKHAND

> The success of Vikshit Bharat 2047 will depend entirely on the functioning and quality of higher education

Higher education in Bharat is at a crossroads. In spite of seventy-nine years of Independence, we have been able to reach less than thirty per cent Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) of the relevant age group (18 to 24-year-olds) in higher education. No nation can expect to be a developed nation or its people prosperous with such low participation in higher education. Education and prosperity are directly proportional to each other. We should have achieved at least fifty percent participation of our youth in higher education by this time. Some states have much lower rates of participation, like Jharkhand, which has nearly eighteen percent GER. No wonder Jharkhand is one of the least developed states in the nation as well. We cannot expect Bharat to become a Vikshit Bharat by 2047 with some of the states performing as poorly as Jharkhand. And we cannot leave the state machinery to mismanage education, even though the states take shelter under the fact that education is in the Concurrent List of the Constitution. We need to ponder how to rescue such states and hand-hold them to reverse the situation.



Issues of education and their impact on future generations rarely become matters of public debate

The University Grants Commission (UGC) was created to regulate the functioning of higher education institutions through an Act of Parliament in 1956. Before that, it was not a statutory body. Through the Act, it acquired the power to regulate universities across the nation. The UGC has been issuing guidelines to all universities to implement its regulations, and such guidelines should be mandatory for HEIs to follow, as they acquire the status of an HEI by virtue of being recognised as such by the UGC. The accreditation and recognition of universities not following the regulations issued by the UGC, in letter and spirit, should be withdrawn, even if the State Government issues orders and directions on university functioning. Every university acquires the status of a university by virtue of being recognised by the UGC. Different processes of universities should be identical, as they are time-tested and globally established. We may not permit local governments to tinker with them by invoking the clause that education is in the Concurrent List, particularly in matters such as the selection of vice-chancellors, deciding on the courses and curriculum that the university will impart, the number of students the university and its colleges will admit, and the process of assessment and certification. We need to refer to the University Education Commission Report, popularly known as the Radhakrishnan Commission (1949), which had clearly laid down the process for the functioning of universities in Independent Bharat. It is not only advisable but imperative that universities be allowed to decide issues such as which colleges will teach which courses, what the curriculum will be, and how the courses will be run.

The National Education Policy 2020 (NEP 2020) has also reiterated the nation's commitment to maintaining this autonomy of institutions and, in fact, further augmenting it by recommending autonomous status for colleges. No outside agency, not even the state government, should be allowed to intervene in such matters. Governments do not have the expertise to decide and direct universities on such issues. It is misplaced to believe that the Departments of Education of the Central or State Governments and their officials understand education better than the universities and their functionaries. The only office that may and can intervene is that of the Chancellor of the university. This needs to be understood and accepted with humility by governments and their officials.

It has become unavoidable to raise the issue of the autonomy of higher education in the public space, as the success of Vikshit Bharat 2047 will depend entirely on the functioning and quality of higher education. No office that is entitled to regulate institutions is ready to hear the stakeholders and domain experts. There is, apparently, an effort to control HEIs. Governments have the power to regulate, so why would they not seek to control universities? And why would the Governor, who happens to be the Chancellor of universities, seek to control them? The first example (though there may have been earlier ones) of such control can be seen in the Act governing Gautam Buddha University, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh. The Government (incidentally headed by Mayawati Ji) decided that the Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh, instead of the Governor, would be the Chancellor of the university. One would have to research the performance of the university and the kind of interference it has experienced over the years. In spite of liberal funding and massive infrastructural development, which is enviable, the university has not really been able to deliver. It is but natural that the political head of the university would like to reap the benefits of his or her position for political gains. The university is bound to become a battleground for using its intellectual as well as infrastructural resources for political ends.

Very recently, the Government of Jharkhand passed the *Jharkhand State Universities Act, 2026* (Jharkhand Act–05, 2026) in April this year. The Act subverts many of the existing established structures of universities. The Act, besides many other departures from established norms, states: "State Government, in consultation with the Chancellor, may nominate any person as the Pro-Chancellor" (emphasis author's). Now, it can be anybody's guess why the State considered it fit to have its nominee alongside the Chancellor. Politicisation of HEIs will be the most damaging influence on these institutions, apart from its adverse impact on maintaining quality. This needs to be discussed, and the common public should be informed and educated about it.

Issues of education and their impact on future generations rarely become matters of public debate, even though they affect individuals, families, and society the most, albeit in the long run. It is the job of intellectuals and academia to raise such issues, but somehow academia has become so cowed down and demoralised that it is unable to perform this 'extension' role assigned to it. It is time universities and academics rose to the occasion and educated the masses as well.

Views expressed are personal

AGEING INDIA

The Coming Grey Wave

India's demographic dividend is gradually giving way to an ageing society, demanding urgent reforms in healthcare, pensions, urban planning and long-term care

AMAL CHANDRA

THE WRITER IS A POLICY ANALYST AND A COLUMNIST

> By 2046, India's elderly population will outnumber children below 15, while over 20% of citizens will be aged 60 or above by 2050

India's public discourse remains focused on youth, jobs and the promise of a demographic dividend. Yet a quieter transformation is underway: India is ageing, and doing so before it is fully prepared. The country's next major social challenge may not be youth unemployment, but ensuring dignity, care and security for a rapidly growing elderly population.

Demographic ageing is often associated with affluent societies such as Japan, Germany or Italy. India still appears, at first glance, too young for such concerns. The median Indian is only around 29 years old. However, demographic transitions do not announce themselves dramatically; they emerge gradually and then reshape societies with astonishing force. The latest India Ageing Report released by the United Nations Population Fund projects that people aged 60 and above will constitute more than 20 per cent of India's population by 2050, nearly double their present share. By 2046, India is expected to have more elderly citizens than children below the age of fifteen. The population aged eighty and above is projected to grow by nearly 279 per cent between 2022 and 2050. These are not distant abstractions. They describe a profound restructuring of Indian society already underway.

What India needs is not a patchwork of welfare schemes but a comprehensive national ageing strategy

The challenge is particularly acute because India is ageing at a lower level of per capita income than most developed countries did. Europe grew old after becoming rich. India risks growing old before becoming adequately prosperous. This distinction matters because ageing places significant demands on healthcare systems, pension structures, social services and public finances. Countries that successfully navigated demographic ageing did so after building extensive welfare institutions. India, by contrast, enters this transition with fragmented social protection, uneven healthcare access and limited long-term care infrastructure.

Kerala offers a glimpse into India's future. With fertility rates having declined decades ago and life expectancy among the highest in the country, Kerala is already experiencing the realities of an ageing society. More than one-sixth of its population is above sixty years of age, and projections suggest the proportion may approach one-third by mid-century. Recognising this reality, Kerala has recently moved towards establishing a dedicated department for elderly welfare while simultaneously revising its senior citizens' policy. These initiatives seek to move ageing from the margins of social welfare administration to the centre of governance. They acknowledge a truth that much of India still overlooks: ageing is not merely a welfare issue; it is a structural policy challenge requiring specialised institutions and sustained planning.

Most Indian states continue to treat older citizens primarily as recipients of pensions rather than as a demographic group requiring comprehensive policy attention. Yet ageing affects every sphere of governance, from housing and transport to healthcare, urban planning and family structures. The most immediate challenge lies in healthcare. India's health system evolved to address infectious diseases, maternal health and child welfare, but an ageing population brings a different burden: chronic illnesses, dementia, cardiovascular disease, cancer, diabetes and age-related disabilities. Long-term care, geriatric medicine, palliative care, and rehabilitation remain inadequate. Hospitals may be designed to treat illness, but ageing societies require systems that can support frailty, dependency and quality of life over extended periods.

The burden is compounded by the feminisation of ageing. Women generally live longer than men and consequently constitute a disproportionately large share of the elderly population, particularly among the oldest age groups. Many are widowed, financially dependent, and vulnerable to social isolation. The India Ageing Report highlights the growing predominance of older women among the very elderly and underscores the gendered nature of poverty in old age. Any serious ageing policy must therefore incorporate gender-sensitive healthcare, income security and social support mechanisms.

Economic insecurity among senior citizens remains another underappreciated concern. A large proportion of India's workforce has spent its productive years in the informal sector without access to contributory pension systems. For millions of elderly Indians, old age coincides with declining earning capacity but without guaranteed income support. Existing social pensions provide important assistance but remain modest and uneven across states. The result is a paradoxical situation in which individuals who contributed to economic growth throughout their lives often confront old age with inadequate financial security.

The fiscal implications are equally significant. As populations age, dependency ratios rise. A smaller proportion of workers supports a larger retired population. This transition can strain public finances if pension obligations expand without corresponding productivity gains. India still possesses a demographic window, but that window is narrowing. The country must use its remaining years of demographic advantage to build pension reserves, strengthen formal employment and expand contributory social insurance systems. Otherwise, future governments may confront escalating welfare obligations without adequate fiscal capacity.

Yet the most consequential transformation may be social rather than economic. Indian society has traditionally relied upon the family as the primary institution of elderly care. The joint family system functioned as an informal welfare state long before modern social security emerged. That model is increasingly under pressure. Urbanisation, migration, smaller family sizes, and changing labour patterns have altered intergenerational relationships. Adult children often live hundreds or thousands of kilometres away from ageing parents. Women, who historically provided much of the unpaid care work, are increasingly participating in the labour force. Longevity means elderly parents may require support for decades rather than years.

Public policy has not adequately adjusted to this reality. India continues to assume that families will absorb care responsibilities even as the social conditions sustaining that assumption erode. The result is an expanding care gap. Elderly individuals frequently find themselves physically alone, emotionally isolated, or dependent upon overstretched family networks. Loneliness, depression, and neglect are emerging public health concerns, though they rarely receive the attention devoted to more visible economic indicators.

Urban planning illustrates the extent to which India remains unprepared. Most Indian cities are designed for mobility, not accessibility. Broken pavements, inadequate public transport, poorly maintained public spaces, and unsafe pedestrian infrastructure create daily obstacles for senior citizens. Age-friendly cities require different priorities: barrier-free public spaces, accessible transport systems, safe crossings, benches, community centres and healthcare facilities within easy reach. As India continues its rapid urban expansion, it has an opportunity to integrate ageing into city design rather than retrofitting infrastructure decades later at greater cost.

Technology can significantly improve elderly care through digital health records, telemedicine, remote monitoring and assistive technologies, but only if it remains accessible to older citizens. At the same time, ageing must not be viewed solely as a burden. Many senior citizens remain healthy, productive, and capable of contributing through work, mentoring, volunteering and community engagement. The objective should be active ageing, supported by age-friendly digital systems and opportunities for continued participation in society.

What India needs is not a patchwork of welfare schemes but a comprehensive national ageing strategy integrating healthcare reform, pension sustainability, long-term care, caregiver support, digital inclusion and age-friendly infrastructure. Kerala's recent initiatives should be seen as a signal to the nation: demographic ageing is no longer a future concern but a present reality. India still has time to prepare, but what is lacking is not evidence of the challenge—it is political recognition. Ageing has arrived; the question is whether governance will arrive in time.

Views expressed are personal

THERE WAS NO IMMEDIATE CLAIM OF RESPONSIBILITY

‘At least six killed, several injured after blast at Damascus cafe’

BEIRUT: A bomb blast at a crowded cafe in central Damascus killed at least six people and wounded 22 others on Thursday, Syrian state media reported. There was no immediate claim of responsibility.

Syrian state television said an explosive device had been planted at the cafe, near the Palace of Justice in the centre of the capital. Damascus Governor Maher Idlibi said the blast was caused by a crudely made improvised explosive device, according to Syrian state media.

Videos that circulated on social media showed wounded people and blood on the floors of a cafe, purportedly the site of the blast. Reuters could not immediately verify the footage.

The attack presents another security challenge to the Syrian government of President Ahmed al-Sharaa, who took control after overthrowing former President Bashar al-Assad in late 2024. Assad's ouster effectively ended more than 14 years of civil war. Damascus has witnessed a handful of security incidents since then, including a car bomb that killed one Syrian soldier and wounded at least 18 people outside the defence ministry in May.

Although no group claimed responsibility for Thursday's blast, Islamic State has sought to exploit the security vacuum created by Assad's ouster by reactivating sleeper cells, recruiting fighters and moving weapons as the new government extends its authority across the country, security officials had said.

The militant group announced earlier this year what it described as a new phase of operations against Sharaa's government.

The group is far weaker than when it controlled large parts of Syria and Iraq before the collapse of its self-declared caliphate in 2019. It remains, however, capable of carrying out deadly insurgency-style attacks and is viewed by Syrian, Iraqi and Western officials as one of the biggest threats to Syria's transition. AGENCIES

Videos that circulated on social media showed wounded people and blood on the floors

Highlights

- » Syrian state television said an explosive device had been planted at the cafe, near Justice Palace
- » Assad's ouster effectively ended more than 14 years of civil war in the country
- » The militant group announced earlier this year what it described as a new phase of operations against Sharaa's government

Russian attack kills 20 in Kyiv

As Ukrainian strikes batter Moscow's oil sector

KYIV: Russia hammered Kyiv in an 11-hour drone and missile attack overnight into Thursday morning, killing at least 20 civilians in the city and injuring scores more in what Moscow said was retaliation for Ukrainian strikes on Russian oil facilities.

Loud explosions shook the Ukrainian capital for hours during the night, with many people sheltering in subway stations after authorities issued air raid warnings. Emergency crews were still digging through the rubble of collapsed and charred apartment buildings in search of victims as dawn broke.

Russia's Defence Ministry said in a statement that the deadly bombardment was in response to Ukraine's long-range strikes that have caused severe fuel shortages and put pressure on President Vladimir Putin.

Ukraine's increasingly frequent and large-scale attacks — described by Zelenskyy as a 40-day blitz — have especially targeted oil refineries, causing a fuel crisis that has frustrated Russians, more than four years after Moscow's full-scale invasion of its neighbour. Ukrainian officials say they are trying to force Putin to the negotiating table, but so far Moscow's response has been to hit back.

Diplomatic efforts to end the war, most recently by the Trump administration, haven't produced results. Putin thinks that time is on his side, that Western support will peter out and that Ukraine's resistance will eventually collapse under pressure from strategic bombing, Western analysts say.

The attack killed 20 people in Kyiv, according to Kyiv city administration head Tymur Tkachenko.

More than 90 others were injured, according to Kyiv Mayor Vitali Klitschko.

Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha said it was a "night of horror" in the capital. AGENCIES

A residential apartment building being seen damaged after a Russian strike on Kyiv on Thursday AP/PTI

> Diplomatic efforts to end the war, most recently by Trump administration, haven't produced results

British PM Starmer issues apology for UK's historic forced adoptions

LONDON: Prime Minister Keir Starmer on Thursday issued an apology on behalf of the British state for thousands of forced adoptions of children born to unwed mothers between the 1950s and 70s.

The government also announced a 4-million-pound support package for better access to adoption records.

In a House of Commons statement, the outgoing leader serving as caretaker PM until his successor is elected paid tribute to the "remarkable women" who were "coerced, bullied or misled" into feeling they had no choice but to have their children taken from them.

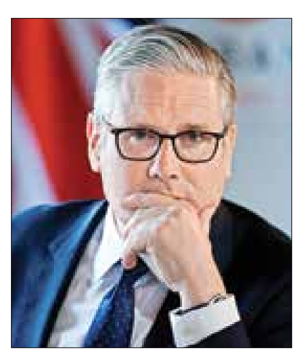
An estimated 1,85,000 babies are believed to have been forcibly taken away by institutions, including religious organisations, from vulnerable young women who fell pregnant.

"What happened to them – and to tens of thousands of mothers, children and families – should never have happened. It is a stain on our history," said Starmer.

"These were not isolated or accidental acts. They were practices embedded within systems across local authorities, across voluntary and faith-based institutions, and in health and social care services, including parts of what is now the NHS [National Health Service].

"I hope this statement and this apology perhaps gives some of them the confidence to speak about what happened to them because it will help in a small way.

"But I say this: the shame is not yours, the shame was never yours, the shame is ours. And I say that on behalf of the whole country, I say it to every single person impacted, we are deeply and profoundly sorry," he said. AGENCIES



UK PM Keir Starmer

> WHAT HAPPENED TO THEM – AND TO TENS OF THOUSANDS OF MOTHERS, CHILDREN AND FAMILIES – SHOULD NEVER HAVE HAPPENED. IT IS A STAIN ON OUR HISTORY

Indians remain largest source of air tourists to Nepal in June

KATHMANDU: Indians remained the largest group of foreign tourists visiting Nepal by air in June, with 41,809 arrivals, registering a 28 per cent increase over the corresponding month last year, according to official data released on Thursday.

Nepal received a total of 91,363 foreign tourists by air during the month, the Nepal Tourism Board (NTB) said.

The number of Indian visitors rose from 32,662 in June last year to 41,809 this year, it said.

During the first six months of 2026, Nepal received 177,159 Indian tourists by air, up 19.27 per cent from 148,540 during the corresponding period last year, the NTB said.

The US was the second-largest source of visitors in June with 11,836 arrivals, followed by China at 9,995, Bangladesh at 4,322 and the UK at 2,500, it said.

Overall, Nepal welcomed 620,426 foreign tourists between January and June this year, recording a 7 per cent increase over the same period in 2025.

Mani R Lamichhane, Senior Director of the Nepal Tourism Board, said the increase in the number of Indian visitors in the recent months can be attributed to high temperatures in Indian cities, long holidays in educational institutions and the Government of India's efforts to encourage domestic and regional travel to reduce foreign exchange outflow. AGENCIES

Andy Burnham wants grooming gang leader deported to Pakistan

LONDON: Andy Burnham, widely expected to succeed Keir Starmer as Britain's new prime minister later this month, is leading calls for the deportation of a grooming gang ringleader to Pakistan after he was released from prison on Thursday.

Burnham, the MP for Makerfield likely to be elected unopposed later this month after Starmer's recent resignation, said he will "review all options" to remove Shabir Ahmed – convicted in 2012 of multiple charges of rape and sexual offences against young girls. The scandal, which rocked Rochdale in Greater Manchester, falls within Burnham's patch as the region's former mayor and has hit the headlines again after it emerged that Ahmed is protected under a 1970s law that blocks his deportation.

"Like everyone, I want this vile criminal out of the country. Victims must come first," said Burnham. "I will ask the Home and Foreign Secretaries to review all possible options – and they should consider nothing is off the table," he said.

Ahmed, a 73-year-old dual national, was stripped of his British citizenship when he was sentenced to 22 years imprisonment by a UK court.

However, a Probation Service letter informing victims of his early release under a prison scheme this week revealed that as per the UK's Immigration Act 1971, any Commonwealth citizen who arrived in the UK before 1973 and had been here for at least five years, cannot be deported.

The issue is said to have been further complicated by the fact that there is reluctance on the part of the receiving country, Pakistan, to accept the criminal. "The government is exploring every option in this case," Sir Alan Campbell, Leader of the House of Commons, told MPs in response to a parliamentary question on Thursday. Ahmed is now being electronically tracked through a GPS tag while housed in a monitored accommodation since his release from prison. AGENCIES

UN asks Pakistan to reverse 'reconstructions' at Taxila sites

ISLAMABAD: The UN has asked Pakistan to reverse the "reconstructions" that "undermined the integrity" of two historical sites in Taxila, a UNESCO World Heritage site, or these would be placed on the agency's "danger list", a media report said on Thursday.

UNESCO, the cultural arm of the UN, in a recent meeting told senior government officials that it would not hesitate to "delist" the historical sites at Mohra Moradu and Sirkap, just like it had "delisted" a World Heritage Site in Germany, due to the recent "unnecessary interventions", the Dawn newspaper reported, quoting sources.

The UN agency warned that it would "delist" Taxila from its World Heritage List if the actions were not reversed.

Taxila, located in the Rawalpindi district of Pakistan's Punjab province, is a vast serial site that includes a Mesolithic cave and the archaeological remains of four early settlement sites, Buddhist monasteries, and a mosque and madrassa.

The ruins of the four settlement sites at Taxila reveal the pattern of urban evolution on the Indian subcontinent through more than five centuries, according to the UNESCO website. In March, a visitor shared information and pictures with Pakistan's Permanent Delegate to UNESCO in Paris, highlighting reconstruction works by the Punjab archaeology department.

The visitor observed interventions that could "affect the authenticity and integrity of the property, specifically original walls being replaced with new construction or their height being raised", the report said.

Subsequently, UNESCO cautioned that "unnecessary interventions" compromised the authenticity and integrity of these sites and could put them at risk of being placed on the "danger list".

Photos showed that fresh masonry works had replaced some ancient walls, and reconstruction was carried out to increase the height of the walls, the report said.

It was easy to discern between old stones, which are irregular in size, and modern building material, which seems polished and uniform in size, the paper reported. AGENCIES

> PHOTOS SHOWED THAT FRESH MASONRY WORKS HAD REPLACED SOME ANCIENT WALLS

BIGGEST FIRE SPREAD IN AUDE, HERAULT

Wildfires scorch southern France as heat, drought fuel blazes

PARIS: Wildfires raged in the south of France on Thursday after weeks of dry weather and record temperatures across the country, devastating large swaths of land.

The biggest fire spread in the Aude and Herault regions, where up to 800 firefighters and 150 vehicles were deployed to tackle the flames that ran over 900 hectares (2,200 acres), local authorities said.

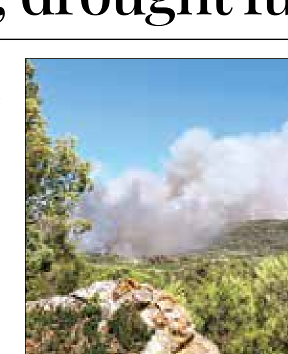
Further fires broke out in the neighbouring Marseille region, where two blazes on Thursday were brought under control, but not yet extinguished.

French Prime Minister Sebastien Lecornu said nearly 7,000 fires have broken out since the start of the summer season, with some 8,700 hectares already burned. "The situation is fairly tense," he said.

In the Aude region, four water-bomber aircraft were deployed to support firefighters.

"The idea is to bring the fire under control quickly because temperatures are rising and the wind is growing stronger," Alain Bucquet, the Aude prefect, told France Info channel.

The Aude is regularly hit by wildfires and firefighters last year contained France's largest wildfire in decades in the region. AGENCIES



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

Airlines shun ₹10K cr aviation fuel subsidy as fuel prices fall

The scheme was voluntary, and airlines were to sign agreements with oil marketing cos to avail of the capped price of about Rs 115 per litre

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Rs 10,000-crore jet fuel price stabilisation programme has failed to take off, with no airline signing up for the scheme as a decline in international oil prices eroded its appeal, sources said.

The Union Cabinet last month approved a one-time Rs 10,000-crore scheme to compensate state-owned fuel retailers for selling aviation turbine fuel (ATF) to airlines at capped prices for upto three years, aiming to shield carriers from surging fuel costs triggered by the West Asia crisis.

The scheme was voluntary, and airlines were to sign agreements with oil marketing companies to avail of the capped price of about Rs 115 per litre. However, no airline has signed up for the scheme so far, sources said.

This could possibly be because international oil prices started to fall around mid-June, making the capped price unattractive.

On July 1, aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices in fact dropped to Rs 110 per litre from Rs 115 rate that was announced on June 9.

Under the voluntary scheme, participating airlines were to pay a fixed free-on-board (FOB) benchmark price of Rs 86.32 per litre, plus airport charges, oil company margins and applicable taxes, resulting in an effective selling price of Rs 115 per litre in Delhi, Rs 114.5 in Mumbai and Rs 139 in Chennai. Airlines that do not opt for the scheme are to pay market-linked prices.

On July 1, ATF prices in fact dropped to Rs 110/litre from Rs 115 rate that was announced on June 9. Market-linked ATF prices were around Rs 142/litre when the scheme was announced on June 3

Highlights

» The scheme was announced to give airlines clarity on fuel prices

» Those opting into the price stabilisation scheme were to continue to receive ATF at Rs 115 per litre for upto three years, insulated from global benchmark fluctuations

» ATF typically accounts for 40% of airline operating expenses & can rise to around 60 per cent during period of sharp volatility

Sources said market-linked ATF prices were around Rs 142 per litre when the scheme was announced on June 3. However, prices have since softened following an interim peace deal between the US and Iran, easing concerns over potential supply disruptions through the Strait of Hormuz, a key global oil shipping route.

The scheme was announced to give airlines clarity on fuel prices. Those opting into the price stabilisation scheme were to continue to receive ATF at Rs 115 per litre for upto three years, insulated from global benchmark fluctuations. While non-participating carriers will benefit from price declines, they also face higher costs when international rates rise.

Sources said the scheme was completely voluntary, and airlines had to make a call if they wanted to participate in it.

With no airlines signing up, the scheme has not technically been put in motion, they said.

When the government announced the capped ATF price of Rs 115 per litre, the prevailing retail price in Delhi was about Rs 105 per litre, a level that had remained unchanged since April after only a partial pass-through of higher global fuel costs triggered by the outbreak of the West Asia conflict in late February. The price freeze resulted in losses for state-owned oil marketing companies on aviation turbine fuel, adding to under-recoveries on petrol, diesel and LPG, sources said.

To address these losses, the Union Cabinet had approved a Rs 10,000-crore price stabilisation scheme aimed at capping ATF prices and shielding airlines from volatility linked to geopolitical tensions, while also supporting the financial health of state-owned oil companies.

Under the scheme, whenever global benchmark prices rose above the base rate of Rs 86.32, the government was to provide an interest-free advance to oil marketing companies to cover the difference. When prices fell, the differential was to be recovered from the companies and returned to the Consolidated Fund of India.

ATF typically accounts for about 40 per cent of airline operating expenses and can rise to as much as 60 per cent during periods of sharp volatility.

Sources said international jet fuel prices had climbed to as high as Rs 142 per litre in May from pre-war rates of Rs 60.50 per litre, raising concerns over airline operating costs and potential fare increases.

The new arrangement, they said, was not a subsidy but a temporary stabilisation framework intended to smooth volatility in fuel prices while ensuring accountability, monitoring and full recovery of funds.

For passengers, the most important benefit of this decision is that it will help to moderate sudden increases in airfares that often result from sharp spikes in fuel prices. By reducing the exposure of airlines to extreme fuel price fluctuations, the government aims to minimise the impact of such costs to travellers and provide greater fare stability.

Odisha inks MoU with Adani Group, IHC for aluminium project

BHUBANESWAR: The Odisha government on Thursday signed an MoU with UAE-based International Holding Company (IHC) and the Adani Group for setting up an integrated aluminium project worth Rs 1.10 lakh crore, officials said.

The venture represents the "largest foreign direct investment in Odisha's history and the biggest FDI proposal in India's metallurgy sector", a senior government official said.

The MoU was signed between IHC and the Industrial Promotion and Investment Corporation of Odisha (IPICOL) in the presence of Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi and senior company officials.

Adani Enterprises Ltd and International Resources Holding (IRH), an IHC Group company, will form a 50:50 joint venture to develop the integrated green field aluminium project in Odisha, an Adani Group statement said.

According to the agreement, the partners will fund the investment through debt and equity for the project.

It will comprise a 4-million tonne per annum (MTPA) alumina refinery, a 2-MTPA aluminium smelter, a 4,000-MW captive power plant, a 1-MTPA downstream manufacturing park, and associated infrastructure.

The proposed facility could create direct and indirect employment for around 53,500 people across mining, refining, smelting, and downstream activities, the official said.

The logistics are likely to be supported through the Dhamra Port – a 100 per cent subsidiary of Adani Ports and SEZ – on the Bay of Bengal, he said.

Majhi said the project will open up "unprecedented opportunities" for industrial growth, employment, and economic transformation of Odisha.

"This investment will enable Odisha to develop the complete aluminium value chain, from mining and refining to smelting and downstream manufacturing," the CM said.

The mega project will be developed in two phases – with investments of Rs 66,000 crore and Rs 44,000 crore, the official said. Though the exact location of the project is yet to be announced, industry sources said the alumina refinery will come up in Rayagada district, while the smelter unit would be set up in Sudargarh district. PTI

AI Express resumes all flights to West Asia

NEW DELHI: Air India Express on Thursday said it has restored services to all destinations in the West Asia network, with flights set to commence to Oman and Kuwait.

The Tata Group-owned airline had suspended services to certain West Asia destinations in the wake of the conflict in the region.

Currently, the carrier operates around 780 weekly flights between India and West Asia connecting 18 Indian cities directly with the region.

With resumption of services to Salalah in Oman and Kuwait, connectivity to all destinations across the West Asia network has been restored, the airline said in a release.

"Flights on the Kozhikode-Salalah route will resume from 2 July. Services between Kozhikode and Kuwait will resume from 3 July, while flights between Bengaluru and Kuwait will begin from 4 July, with frequencies increasing in phases over the coming days," it said.

With a fleet of over 100 planes, Air India Express operates more than 500 flights daily connecting 43 domestic and 16 international destinations. PTI

'India-Japan ties anchor vital trade, investment dimensions'

Goyal highlighted that the bilateral engagement witnessed a significant increase following a reset into a comprehensive strategic partnership

NEW DELHI: The India-Japan relationship has both trade and investment dimensions, said Union Minister of Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal. He mentioned that this comprehensive strategic partnership continues to expand across critical infrastructure, trade baskets, and high-technology sectors like semiconductors.

Speaking at the Indo-Japan Strategic Dialogue hosted by NDTV on Thursday, Goyal highlighted that the bilateral engagement witnessed a significant increase following a reset into a comprehensive strategic partnership. This momentum gained further traction after the 15th Japan-India Summit, where Japan committed to investing 100 trillion yen, equivalent to approximately $65-70 billion, across various Indian sectors, infrastructure, and industry.

Japan's bilateral trade with India totaled $27.47 billion during FY 2025-26. Exports from Japan to India during this period were $21.43 billion, and imports were $6.04 billion.

Today, India ranks 14th in Japan's total trade with a 1.75 per cent share, while Japan ranks 10th in India's total trade with a 2.26 per cent share.

Union Minister of Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal

'What we sell to Japan are also value-added products. We are not selling raw materials or intermediates'

Highlights

- » India ranks 14th in Japan's total trade with 1.75% share, while Japan ranks 10th in India's total trade with a 2.26% share
- » India ranks 8th in Japan's total exports with 2.61% share, Japan ranks 21st in India's total exports with a 1.37% share
- » India ranks 22nd in Japan's total imports with 0.98% share & Japan ranks 10th in India's total imports with a 2.76% share

India ranks 8th in Japan's total exports with a 2.61 per cent share, and Japan ranks 21st in India's total exports with a 1.37 per cent share. India ranks 22nd in Japan's total imports with a 0.98 per cent share, and Japan ranks 10th in India's total imports with a 2.76 per cent share.

Addressing the trade dynamic, Goyal explained that the partnership relies on complementary strengths. India imports technology-driven products from Japan, while exporting high-quality, precision-engineered materials, auto components, and electronic components.

"What we sell to Japan are also value-added products. We are not selling raw materials or intermediates," Goyal stated.

India's primary exports to Japan are Organic Chemicals, Vehicles (Other than railways & trams), Nuclear Reactor, Aluminium and Articles thereof, Fish & other aquatic invertebrates.

India's primary imports from Japan are nuclear reactors, copper and articles thereof, electrical machinery and equipment, inorganic chemicals and iron and steel. The partnership also extends to regional development, notably through India's Act East policy. Goyal described the Northeast region as a natural gateway for trade with the ASEAN region due to its geographical proximity and talented workforce.

He noted that joint efforts by India and Japan to promote industry and infrastructure in the Northeast align with the government's commitment to equitable development across all regions.

Furthermore, Goyal discussed the success of India's semiconductor mission, which now includes almost 12 major initiatives. He noted that global companies recognize Indian talent, given that Indians comprise nearly 20 per cent of design engineers in the semiconductor field. According to the Minister, Japan is among the friendly nations keen to see India integrate into the global semiconductor supply chain, supported by an existing $100 billion domestic semiconductor market.

The Minister noted that Japan's historical economic engagement with India focused largely around investments. He cited the transformative impact of Maruti Suzuki, which entered the Indian market nearly 40 years ago and introduced modern, affordable, technology-driven automobiles, ultimately positioning India to become a global power in the automotive sector. "Just reading the figures for last month, Maruti Suzuki has 147,000 car share out of 400,000 passenger vehicles sold in India in the month of May," Goyal added, emphasizing the company's substantial role in specific industry segments.

The dialogue also touched upon human capital and the services sector, particularly Japan's requirement for highly skilled caregivers. Goyal emphasized the necessity of language and cultural training to secure these high-paying opportunities. He shared that his own skill development center in Mumbai runs classes on Japanese language & culture to help students secure employment in Japan. ANI

New EPFO scheme eyes digital compliance, faster claim approval

The Ministry of Labour has made contributions in EPF beyond Rs 1,800, voluntary under new EPF Scheme 2026

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Digital compliance and timely settlement of claims, such as PF withdrawal and pension fixation, will be the focus areas of the new social security scheme managed by the retirement fund body, EPFO.

The Ministry of Labour & Employment has notified the Employees' Provident Funds Scheme, 2026, Employees' Pension Scheme, 2026 and Employees' Deposit-Linked Insurance Scheme, 2026 under the new Code on Social Security.

The ministry has made a strict provision for payment of 12 per cent penal rate of interest for not settling claims within 20 days regarding withdrawal of provident fund, pension and group insurance by officials of the retirement fund body EPFO under the new schemes.

The new schemes provide that "Where the Commissioner fails without sufficient cause to settle a claim complete in all respects within twenty days, the Commissioner shall be liable for the delay beyond the said period and penal interest at the rate of twelve per cent per annum may be charged on the benefit amount, which shall be deducted from the salary of the Commissioner."

These newly notified schemes will replace the Employees' Provident Funds Scheme, 1952, the Employees' Family Pension Scheme, 1971, the Employees' Pension Scheme, 1995, and the Employees' Deposit-Linked Insurance Scheme, 1976.

A senior official said there was a provision for payment of penal rate of interest for delay in settling the claim completed in all respects in earlier schemes also.

He explained that earlier the officials were required to pay the declared rate of interest on PF deposits and now they have fixed it at 12 per cent.

The official also explained that there is no major change in terms of contribution to be made by employees and employers towards the social security schemes run by the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO).

The employers as well as employees continue to contribute 12 per cent of basic wage, toward the social security schemes.

The contribution to the pension scheme will be 8.33 per cent from employers' contribution, and the government will chip in a subsidy of 1.16 per cent as earlier.

However, he explained that the stress is on digital compliance by employers as well as the EPFO, so that the members can avail all services seamlessly online without any delay.

The exempted establishments or the PF trusts regulated by the EPFO are also required to make provision for online filing of claims and other applications by their members under the new schemes.

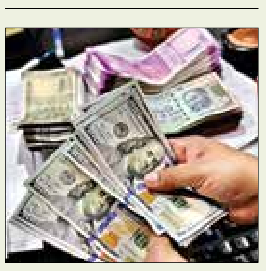
Further, the ministry has made all contributions in the Employees' Provident Fund (EPF) above the monthly wage ceiling of Rs 15,000, which is beyond Rs 1,800, voluntary under the new Employees' Provident Funds Scheme 2026 notified on Monday.

Earlier, under the old scheme, the Employees' Provident Funds Scheme 1952, the wage ceiling, which is Rs 15,000 per month at present, was relevant at the time of joining a firm for providing the employee with mandatory social security cover.

All employees whose basic wages were up to Rs 15,000 were mandatorily covered under the scheme and others had the option to join the social security schemes run by the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO), voluntarily.

Once covered under the scheme, employees used to contribute on their actual basic wages and employers used to match that contribution, which were even higher than the wage ceiling notified by the government from time to time.

Rupee falls 19 paise to 95.35 against dollar



MUMBAI: The rupee pared initial gains and settled for the day on a negative note, lower by 19 paise at 95.35 against the US dollar on Thursday, as the support from easing crude oil prices was negated by robust dollar demand from importers and corporate hedgers.

Forex traders said the Indian rupee opened higher on an overnight decline in the US dollar following less hawkish comments from Fed Chair Kevin Warsh and a fall in crude oil prices.

However, the rupee lost its initial gains on FII outflows and dollar demand from hedgers.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 94.95 against the American currency and traded in a range of 94.90-95.42 during the session.

The rupee finally closed at 95.35, registering a decline of 19 paise from its previous close.

On Wednesday, the rupee depreciated 60 paise to close at 95.16 against the US dollar.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 101.00, lower by 0.38 per cent. PTI

India's pvt credit market doubles to $25 billion in 5 years: Moody's

NEW DELHI: India's private credit market has doubled in size in the past five years to about $25 billion in Assets Under Management (AUM) as of 2025 end, and will further expand amid strong financing demand, Moody's Ratings said on Thursday. However, the new RBI norms which allow banks to finance acquisitions will increase competition in a segment historically dominated by alternative capital.

"While the new rules may benefit borrowers by lowering costs for financing and increasing its availability, they could compress yields and reduce deal flows for private credit providers for acquisition financing," Moody's said.

As per the new RBI rules effective July 1, RBI, for the first time, has allowed banks to fund strategic acquisitions of equity shares and compulsorily convertible debentures, subject to certain conditions.

Real estate sector accounts for about 40% of the total value of pvt credit

Moody's said India's private credit market has expanded rapidly over the past five years, evolving from a source of financing primarily for distressed companies to a provider of credit for a wider mix of financially stable businesses.

"India's private credit market has grown rapidly in the past five years – to more than $11 billion in annual transaction value in 2025 and about $25 billion in AUM as of the end of that year – it remains small by global standards", Moody's said.

Its growth will accelerate as funding needs in the country increase amid strong economic conditions, it added.

Although still small by global standards, India's private credit market has significant headroom to grow, supported by expanding financing needs and the country's robust macroeconomic momentum.

The real estate sector accounts for about 40 per cent of the total value of private credit, while infrastructure and utilities companies make up the next largest shares. Financing led by promoters across various sectors – often for refinancing, liability management or stake acquisitions – is another key part of the private credit market in India, Moody's said. PTI

Markets rally for 2nd day, Sensex up 579 pts on easing crude oil prices and buying in IT

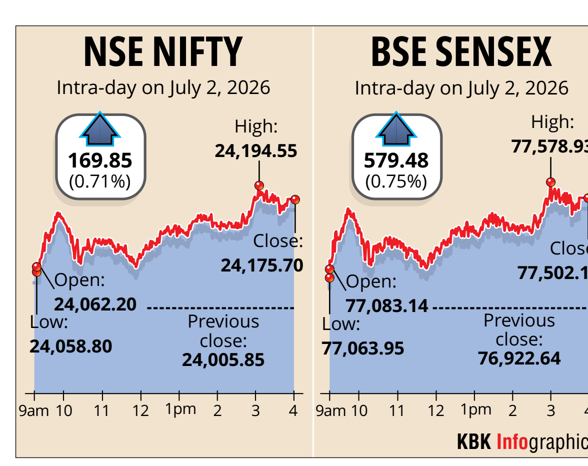
MUMBAI: Stock market benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty ended nearly one per cent higher on Thursday amid softening crude oil prices, following positive developments on the geopolitical front and buying in blue-chip IT stocks.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 579.48 points, or 0.75 per cent, to end at 77,502.12. During the day, it surged 656.29 points, or 0.85 per cent, to 77,578.93.

The 50-share NSE Nifty rallied 169.85 points, or 0.71 per cent, to settle at 24,175.70.

From the Sensex pack, Infosys jumped 5.64 per cent, followed by Tech Mahindra (4.32 per cent), Tata Consultancy Services (4.28 per cent) and HCL Tech (4.12 per cent).

Bajaj Finserv, Adani Ports,



Titan and ICICI Bank were also among the major gainers.

Larsen & Toubro, Maruti Suzuki India, Axis Bank and Reliance Industries were among the laggards.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, dropped 1.45 per cent to $70.53 per barrel.

Sectorally, IT surged 4.37 per cent, Focused IT (4.29 per cent), Consumer Durables (1.45 per cent), Realty (1.43 per cent), Auto (1.33 per cent), Consumer Discretionary (1.11 per cent) and Commodities (1.06 per cent).

Industrials, Telecommunication, Capital Goods and Power were the laggards.

The BSE MidCap Select index jumped 0.94 per cent and the SmallCap Select index climbed 0.68 per cent.

A total of 2,536 stocks advanced, while 1,740 declined and 182 remained unchanged on the BSE.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 1,140.50 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

On Wednesday, the Sensex climbed 443.97 points, or 0.58 per cent, to settle at 76,922.64. The Nifty rallied 140.10 points, or 0.59 per cent, to end at 24,005.85. PTI

FPIs pull out ₹49,340 cr from equities in June

NEW DELHI: Foreign investors extended their selling spree in June, withdrawing Rs 49,340 crore ($5.16 billion) from Indian equities, triggered by a combination of early-month global risk aversion, a preference for developed markets, soaring US bond yields, and stretched valuations in the domestic market.

With the latest outflows, total withdrawals by Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) from Indian equities have surged to Rs 2.7 lakh crore so far in 2026, surpassing the Rs 1.66 lakh crore pulled out during the entire calendar year 2025, according to data from the Central Depository Services (India) Ltd.

According to the data, FPIs remained net sellers in every month of 2026 except February. They withdrew Rs 35,962 crore in January before turning net buyers in February, investing Rs 22,615 crore, marking the highest monthly inflow in 17 months.

The trend, however, reversed sharply in March, when foreign investors pulled out a record Rs 1.17 lakh crore.

The selling pressure continued in April with net outflows of Rs 60,847 crore and in May with withdrawals of Rs 32,963 crore. In June, Foreign Portfolio Investors withdrew Rs 49,340 crore.

As a result, the pace of FPI selling moderated later in the month, although it was not enough to offset the sizeable outflows recorded earlier.

V K Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist at Geojit Investments, attributed two factors to the moderation in FPI activity – stabilisation and appreciation of the rupee against the dollar, and heavy FPI profit-booking amid high volatility in the South Korean and Taiwanese markets.

Given the importance of foreign portfolio flows in financing the current account deficit and supporting the balance of payments, policymakers announced a series of measures in June aimed at attracting overseas capital.

These include the RBI absorbing hedging costs on FCNR deposits mobilised by commercial banks, expanding the forex swap window, increasing access to government bonds through the Fully Accessible Route (FAR), and raising investment limits for non-resident Indians and overseas citizens of India in domestic equities.

In contrast to the equity outflows, Foreign Portfolio Investors invested Rs 21,652 crore in debt securities through the Fully Accessible Route route during June and Rs 3,246 crore through the voluntary retention route. PTI

Sundeep Sikka joins India-Japan summit for second time in row

NEW DELHI: Sundeep Sikka, MD and CEO of Nippon Life India Asset Management (NAM India), participated in the 16th India-Japan Annual Summit in New Delhi, becoming the only CEO from India's BFSI sector invited to join Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi.

Sikka had also attended the previous edition of the summit in Tokyo, while NAM India was the only BFSI company invited to both editions, highlighting its growing role in strengthening India-Japan economic ties.

Sikka said India and Japan share a strong partnership across political, cultural, economic and social spheres, with bilateral ties reaching new heights under the leadership of the two Prime Ministers.

As part of Nippon Life Insurance, one of Japan's largest financial institutions with over $600 billion in assets under management, NAM India remains committed to facilitating greater capital flows from Japan and enabling retail and institutional investors to participate in India's long-term growth story, he added. MPOST

'₹1 lakh cr crude savings by 2030 as 35L EVs replace petrol vehicles'

EV adoption has accelerated significantly following the onset of the West Asia conflict in Feb 2026, says SBI report

NEW DELHI: Around 35 lakh more electric vehicles (EVs) are expected to replace petrol vehicles during 2027-2030, helping India save nearly Rs 1 lakh crore in crude oil import bills if EVs account for 20 per cent of the vehicle market by 2030, according to a report by the SBI.

The report said EV adoption has accelerated significantly following the onset of the West Asia conflict in February 2026, with registrations witnessing a sharp rise. It stated, "Our estimate indicates that during the four-year period of 2027-2030, 35 lakh more EVs are expected to replace the petrol vehicles.... EV vehicles have now reached more than an 8 per cent share in 2026. A 20 per cent share by 2030 could save Rs 1 lakh crore of the import bill."

According to the report, average monthly EV registrations increased to 2.3 lakh during March-June 2026 from an average of 1.3 lakh in 2025, an increase of around 1 lakh vehicles per month.

Based on the current trend, SBI expects total EV registrations to cross the 25 lakh mark in 2026.

SBI said the growing market share of EVs in passenger cars, two-wheelers and three-wheelers after February 2026 indicates that the impact of the West Asia conflict has accelerated consumer interest in electric mobility.

CLOSER LOOK

- » 'EV vehicles have now reached over 8% share in 2026. A 20% share by 2030 could save Rs 1L cr of import bill'
- » 'Average monthly EV registrations rose to 2.3 lakh from March-June 2026 from an average 1.3 lakh in 2025'
- » Based on the current trend, SBI expects total EV registrations to cross the 25 lakh mark in 2026

To support faster adoption, the report stressed the need to expand charging infrastructure, particularly fast chargers. At present, fast chargers account for only around 30 per cent of the country's charging network.

The report called for a comprehensive 10-15-year EV roadmap with clear targets covering vehicle segments, charging infrastructure, regulatory policies and battery manufacturing.

It also suggested measures such as creating an EV Credit Guarantee Fund, providing concessional land for public charging stations, increasing government procurement of electric vehicles and introducing a dedicated green mobility category to strengthen the EV ecosystem.

SBI observed that the burden on charging stations varies widely across states. In some states, each charging station serves more than 200 EVs, while in others, the number is around 50 vehicles per charging station.

According to the report, India currently has 29,151 charging stations, with Karnataka and Maharashtra together accounting for 35 per cent of the total charging infrastructure.

The report noted that states such as Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh and Goa have performed better in terms of fast charging infrastructure, with fast chargers accounting for more than 50 per cent of their total charging stations.

It also highlighted that the Delhi government plans to install 32,000 charging points over the next four years under its new EV policy. ANI

BANK OF INDIA DIVIDEND

Bank of India (BoI) presented a dividend cheque of Rs 1,553.50 crore to Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman for the financial year 2025-26 (FY26). The cheque, dated June 17, was handed over on June 30 by MD and CEO Rajneesh Karnatak after the bank reported a 14.19% rise in annual net profit. MPOST

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Sanjay, S/o: Kishan Chand, R/o: Ground & First Floor, Premises Opp. to House No-35, Prem Nagar, Basti Rewala, Khanpur, Najafgarh, New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to has committed) the offence in case **CT No.: 712/2023, U/s: 135 Indian Electricity Act, P.S. Chhawla, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon returned that the said **Sanjay** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Sanjay** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sanjay** of **P.S. Chhawla, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **07.08.2026.**

By Order
Ms. Harleen Singh
ASJ (South West Distt.),
Special Court Electricity, Room No. 609,
Dwarka Courts, New Delhi

DP/8904/DW/2026

RAIL COACH FACTORY, KAPURTHALA

On-line bids are invited by PCMM, RCF on behalf of President of India for following items:-

S. No.	Tender No. and Due Date	Description	Quantity (Nos./Sets)	EMD (Rs.)
1.	12261176 27.07.2026	Set of Window Inner Frame for LHB SCN, LHB GS & LHB SLRD Amrit Bharat Coaches (03 Types)	61 Sets 72 Sets 21 Sets	3,44,360/-
2.	12261149A 23.07.2026	Windows for Non AC Coaches	2248 Nos.	11,27,380/-
3.	12261127 28.07.2026	Set of FRP Panels for Side Wall/Flat Ceiling for MEMU Coaches (4 Types)	403 Sets 100 Sets 137 Sets 76 Sets	4,12,980/-
4.	02261303 29.07.2026	Supply and Installation of one number of Aerosol Generator 500 GMS		4,82,860/-
5.	02261301 04.08.2026	Emergency Talk Back Unit (ETBU)		6,35,100/-
6.	17261223 22.07.2026	Set of SS Items for WEC Coach of Bangladesh Railway	68 Sets	1,99,820/-
7.	12261102A 27.07.2026	Set of Seats for 3-Phase MEMU/TC & MEMU/DMC Coaches (2 Types)	82 Sets 258 Sets	20,00,000/-
8.	12261145A 30.07.2026	Arrangement of UIC Rubber Vestibule	743 Nos.	9,70,560/-
9.	02261293 28.07.2026	Condensed Aerosol based Fire Detection & Suppression System & Associated Accessories		1,82,520/-
10.	14261058 27.07.2026	Epoxy based Elastified Top Coat (2 Components)	180420.00 Litre	6,11,880/-
11.	14261057 23.07.2026	Adhesion Promoting Primer	159214.00 Litre	8,41,670/-
12.	12261162 03.08.2026	Supply and Installation of one Coach Set of Entrance Hand Rail for Train Set MC, TC, NDTC/EC & NDTC/EC2 Coaches	174 Sets	2,83,350/-
13.	17261277 27.07.2026	Supply & Fitment of Set of Mounting Arrangement of Compartment Door for AC 3T Amrit Bharat Coaches	100 Sets	1,03,680/-
14.	12261184 10.08.2026	HT Compartment SS Hatch Door HT Compartment SS Hatch Door	73 Nos. 73 Nos.	1,18,880/-
15.	13265108 23.07.2026	Stretch Forming Machine for Roof Arch Bending. PL No./ Item Code : 659044890019	01 No.	1,28,840/-
16.	12261138 23.07.2026	Foot Step Arrangement for MEMU/TC 3-Phase Coache	1842 Nos.	2,72,480/-
17.	02261290 29.07.2026	Supply, Testing and Commissioning (including all Connections and Dressing W/O Loading) of Set of Panel (Switch Board Cabinet) for LHB EOG Non AC Coach		7,35,380/-
18.	02261118A 28.07.2026	Harness of Underframe and Roof Arrangement for LHB Power Car Type Coaches		7,28,110/-
19.	05261327 04.08.2026	1. Under Frame Complete for Vande Bharat DTC Coach 2. Under Frame Complete for Vande Bharat NDTCEC Coaches 3. Under Frame Complete for Vande Bharat MC Coaches 4. Under Frame Complete for Vande Bharat TC Coaches	12 Nos. 10 Nos. 40 Nos. 21 Nos.	20,00,000/-
20.	05261461 24.07.2026	Set of Endwall Complete for HSPART Coaches	10 Sets	1,51,590/-
21.	05261409 21.07.2026	Set of Side Buffer Assly	149 Sets	6,83,940/-
22.	05261425 20.07.2026	Set of Pillar Assembly	152 Sets	1,64,810/-
23.	05261342A 03.08.2026	Nose Cone for MEMU DMC 3-Phase Coaches	134 Sets	20,00,000/-

1. For details and making on-line bids, visit website **http://ireps.gov.in.** Drawings/specifications, wherever required can be downloaded from RCF website **http://www.rcf.indianrailways.gov.in.** Class III-b digital signature certificate required for on-line bidding, can be obtained from licensed certifying agencies listed at **http://www.cce.gov.in.** **2.** Tenders will close at 14.25 Hrs. on due date and tenders will be opened at 14.30 hrs. Tender at Sl. No. 1 to 20 will be opened at RCF Kapurthala and Sl. No. 21 to 23 at Tilak Bridge, New Delhi. **3.** For queries, contact IREPS Helpdesk at 011-24102855, 011-24105180 or RCF helpdesk at 011-23378658.

Note: GST Number of RCF is 03AAAGM0289C1ZT. All the suppliers are advised to quote this in dispatch documents for the supplies made by them. **PCMM**

CORRIGENDUM

Tenderers may please note the following changes in 1. Tender No. 17261018A for Procurement of Design, Supply, Installation & Commissioning of Interior Furnishing Items of One Rake Set for HS-SPART, Due date to be read as 06.07.2026 instead of 25.06.2026. **2.** Tender No. 17261199 for Procurement of Manufacture, Supply, Installation and Supervision of Interior Furnishings, Fittings, Driver's Cab's Furnishing of High-Speed Self Propelled Inspection Car (HS-SPIC), Due date to be read as 10.07.2026 instead of 30.06.2026. **3.** Tender No. 17261094 for Procurement of Supply and Installation of Interior Furnishing of One Rake Set of Namo Bharat Rapid Rail (16 Car Formation), Due date to be read as 09.07.2026 instead of 29.06.2026. **4.** Tender No. 17251269A for Procurement of Supply, Installation, Commissioning, Testing & CAMC of Fire Detection cum Suppression System (FDSS) in Toilet of Non-AC Coaches, Due date to be read as 13.07.2026 instead of 03.07.2026. **5.** Tender No. 17251268A for Procurement of Supply, Installation, Commissioning, Testing & CAMC of Automatic Fire/Smoke Detection System for ICF Non-AC Coaches, Due date to be read as 13.07.2026 instead of 03.07.2026. **6.** Tender No. 17251398A for Procurement of Supply, Installation, Commissioning, Testing & CAMC of Automatic Fire/Smoke Detection System for MEMU/EMU/DEMU Rake (1 Rake Consist of 12 Coaches), Due date to be read as 13.07.2026 instead of 03.07.2026. **All other terms & conditions will remain the same.** **PCMM**

R.O. No. 35-S/2026-27 **Dated 02.07.2026**

NAVA RAIPUR ATAL NAGAR VIKAS PRADHIKARAN

Paryavas Bhawan, North Block, Sector-19, Nava Raipur Atal Nagar- 492002, Chhattisgarh
Tel No. +91 7712512000; Fax No. +91 7712512400.
Website: www.navaraipuratalnagar.com http://eproc.cgstate.gov.in

E-Procurement Tender Notice

The Chief Executive Officer, **NRANVP** invites tener for the following work:- NIT No: 25/HDPE-DUCT/EEE/CE/NRANVP/2026-27, Nava Raipur Atal Nagar, Dist. Raipur, Dated: 01.07.2026 **Name of Work: "Supplying and laying of HDPE Ducts for OFC Cable laying along City and Sector-Level Roads in Nava Raipur Atal Nagar, District Raipur (C.G.)" (1st Call)**
Estimated cost: INR 15.69 Crore., EMD: INR 16.00 Lakhs, Period of Completion: 18 Months, Last Time & Date of Online Submission: 15:00hrs on 22.07.2026
The E-Procurement tender documents can be downloaded from the portal (Website) **http://eproc.cgstate.gov.in** directly and shall be submitted online on the same website only after making on payment of bid participation fees online.
Amendment in tender, if any, will only be uploaded on the website and shall not be published in any newspaper

Sd/- Superintending Engineer,
NRANVP

samvad 48327/2

DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS KATHUA

E mail: sspkathua@jkpolice.gov.in
Fax/Phone No.: 01922-234010

On 11-06-2026, one person Radha Kumar S/O Chajju Ram R/O Ward No. 13 Hiranagar Tehsil Hiranagar District Kathua lodged a written report at P/S Hiranagar stating therein that on 10-06-2026 his minor daughter namely Anu Bala, age 13 years has been kidnapped from his home at about 1400 hrs. The complainant and other family members made every possible effort to trace her whereabouts, but all in vain. On this, a case FIR No. 65/2026 U/S 137(2)/332(c)/115(2) BNS dated 11-06-2026 has been registered at Police Station Hiranagar. During the course of investigation, best efforts were made to locate missing individual, whereas she is still un-traced.

As such Description Roll/Photograph of said missing individual is being shared with the appeal that anybody having clue/information about her whereabouts may inform us accordingly. The informer will be rewarded suitably:-

Description Roll:-

•Name	Anu Bala
•Father	Radha Kumar
•Permanent Address	Ward No. 13 Hiranagar
•Present Address	Ward No. 13 Hiranagar
•Tehsil	Hiranagar
•Police Station	Hiranagar
•Age	13 years
•Height	5 feet
•Complexion	Wheatish
•Built	Normal
•Face	Oval
•Eyes	Black
• Languages known	Hindi/ Dogri

Any information related to the whereabouts of the subject may be communicated on following contacts:-

1. DPO Kathua- 01922-234010 (Phone/Fax)
2. dpokathua@jkpolice.gov.in (Mail ID)
3. PCR Kathua- 01922-234311(Phone/Fax)
4. Police Station Hiranagar – 01922-27422/9103007511

Sd/-
Sr. Superintendent of Police,
Kathua

DIP No:DIP/J-4882/26

Public Work Department

Office of the Executive Engineer Public Works (West) Division Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar
Address :- Public Works Premise, Padampura, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar 431005
E-mail aaddress :- westaurangabad.ee@mahapwd.gov.in Telephone/Fax Number :-0240 2331288

E-Tender Notice No.(07) of 2026-27

E-Tender for the following work in B-1 Tender Form is invited via online e- tendering system from Eligible Contractor by the Executive Engineer, Public Works (west) Division, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar on behalf of Public Works Department, Government of Maharashtra Tender Document are downloaded from goverment portal https://pwd.maharashtra.gov.in Right to select or reject is reserved by Executive Engineer, Public works (west) Division. Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar. Conditional Tender will be not accepted. (Number of 02 Works)

All information of e-tender is available on following portal.

A) https://pwd.maharashtra.gov.in
B) https://mahatenders.gov.in
If any change made in this e-tender is informed on above portal.

Dgipr/2026-27/1452

Executive Engineer,
Public works(west)Division,
Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Sandeep** S/o Uday Raj R/o H. No. 305 near Primary School Metro Vihar, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 51/2023 dated 09.01.2023 U/s 323/342 IPC, PS Narela Industrial Area, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Sandeep** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sandeep** has absconded or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant. Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sandeep** in **FIR No. 51/2023 dated 09.01.2023 U/s 323/342 IPC, PS Narela Industrial Area, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.08.2026**.

By order
Sh. Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
North, Room No. 6
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/8803/ON/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Shaukat, S/o Fandebaz, R/o Jhuggi Murga Mandi, Gazipur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 94/2018, U/s 224 IPC, P.S. GTB Enclave, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Shaukat** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Shaukat** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Shaukat** accused of **FIR No. 94/2018, U/s 224 IPC, P.S. GTB Enclave, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **06.08.2026**.

By Order - Ms. Sanghmitra
Judicial Magistrate First Class-01
Shahdara Distrcit, Room No. 54, 2nd Floor
Karkarduma Courts, Delhi

DP/8943/SHD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) **Avinash @ Don, S/o:** Sharwan **R/o:** C-240, Near Durga Medical, Inderpuri, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 44/2026, U/s: 307/317(2)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita-2023, PS: Civil Llnes, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Avinash @ Don,** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Avinash @ Don,** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Avinash @ Don,** of **FIR No. 44/2026, U/s: 307/317(2)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita-2023, PS: Civil Lines, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **07.08.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Kartik Taparia
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06
Central District Room No. 247
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/8862/N/2026
(Court Matter)

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No: 4820262027 **Date: 29.06.2026**

E-Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering) / North Central Railway / Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites E-TENDERS by Two Packet System on prescribed form for the following work up to **13:30** hrs. on **22.07.2026.** The details of the Tender is as under:

SN: 1 | **Tender No.:** 113 | **Approx Cost (₹) :** ₹ 119217000.00

Name of work: Supply, stacking and loading of machine crushed track ballast in to Railway's Wagons/Hoppers at Chaunrah (CNH) Ballast Depot in the section of ADEN/ETW under Sr. DEN/III/PRYJ.

Earnest Money (₹) : ₹ 2384300.00 | **Completion on Period:** 12 Months

Date of Opening of tender: 22.07.2026

Eligibility Criteria for Similar work: Supply of machine crushed stone ballast\machine crushed coarse stone aggregate.

Note: **(1)** Tenderers have to submit following test report along with their tender document from any reputed Govt. organization / Institutions as per list given in the tender document (Para 3.1 of Specification for Track Ballast of Tender Document) otherwise their tender will not be considered and summarily rejected: **(i)** Size Gradation Test **(ii)** Abrasion Value Test **(iii)** Impact Value Test **(iv)** Water Absorption Test **(2)** E-Tender Forms shall be issued free of cost to all tenderers. **(3)** The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders are available on Website **www.ireps.gov.in.** up to **13:30** hrs. on the due date of tender opening i.e. 22.07.2026. **(4)** Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificate issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. **(5)** Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form / letter head if attached by vendors shall be straightway ignored and shall not be considered. **(6)** The tenderers shall submit a document verification certificate as given in tender document as "Annexure" in standard format without which their tender may not be considered and shall be summarily rejected. **(7)** The supplier / contractor of goods and / or services would be subject to GST Act and Rules as applicable from time to time. **(8)** Document being attached should be signed by the tenderer on its body. **(9)** This tender notice has also been uploaded on www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in. **(10)** Payment of Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) in respect of e-tendering shall be accepted through net banking or payment gateway only. **(11)** In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. **(12)** Tender on line can be submitted up to 13.30 hrs. of tender opening date i.e. 22.07.2026. **(13)** The tender offer shall be made online through Two Packet System i.e. (1) Technical Bid & (ii) Financial Bid. **(14) The tenderer has to submit necessary documents in compliance of clause 10 to 18 (Part-I) of IRGCC 2022 mandatorily, otherwise offer will be considered as Incomplete Offer and accordingly shall not be considered.** **1492/26(DG)**

North central railways @CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Sanjay S/o Taraniwar R/o RC-514, Sarswati Vihar, Khora Colony, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 123/2013, PS Mandawali, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Sanjay** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Sanjay** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Sanjay** of case **FIR No. 123/2013, PS Mandawali, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **29.08.2026.**

By Order
Sachin Kumar
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
East Dist., Court No. 16
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/8134/ED/2026
(Court Matter)

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Procurement Tender Notice No. JHS/DYCMM/2026/24 Date: 30.06.2026

E-Procurement Tender Notice

On behalf of the President of India, Dy. Chief Materials Manager, Office North Central Railway, Jhansi, invites the following E-procurement Tenders.

S. N.	Tender No.	Short Description	Qty.	Earnest money Deposit (₹)
1	51265666	Set of TPU Ring (Happy Pad) for primary suspension of Fiat bogies to RDSO Drg. No. CG-20049 Alt. 1 item-1&2 (01 Nos. each per set)	10040 Set	₹ 2,84,340/-

Tender Opening Date : 20.07.2026

Note:- The Complete information of above tenders can be seen and download from IREPS website i.e. **https://www.irpes.gov.in**. For any change/ corigendum in tender, please visit this website regularly. No separate corrigendum/change will be published in news paper. **1494/26 (MG)**

North central railways @CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice No.: JHS/Br/L/2026-27/08 **Date : 30.06.2026**

E-Tendering Tender Notice

Dy.Chief Engineer/Bridge/Line/Jhansi, North Central Railway, Jhansi for and on behalf of President of India invites open E- tenders on the prescribed forms for the under noted work:-

Tender No.: Br-JHS-2026-08, **Name of work:** Provision of FOB 03 m wide with ramps for recoupment of shortfall in Minimum Essential Amenities at Jiron (JRO) under VGLJ-BINA Section.

Approx. Cost of work: ₹ 4,95,94,303.02/-

Bid Security (Earnest Money: ₹ 9,91,900.00/-

Date of closing Tender: 22.07.2026 | **Completion period:** 10 Months

Eligibility Criteria for similar work: "Fabrication and erection/launching of steel bridges/FOB"

Note: **(1)** The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders are available on Website **www.ireps.gov.in**. up to **15:00** hrs. on the due to date of tender closing i.e. **22.07.2026**. **(2)** Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificate issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. **(3)** Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form/letter head if attached by vendors shall be straightway ignored and shall not be considered. **(4)** Document being attached should be signed by the tenderer on its body. **(5)** Payment of Bid Security (Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) in respect of e-tendering shall be accepted through net banking or payment gateway or bank guarantee only. **(6)** In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. **(7)** Tender on line can be submitted up to **15.00** hrs. on dated **22.07.2026**. **1502/26 (MG)**

North central railways @CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

Notice

POWERGRID RAMGARH TRANSMISSION LIMITED

(100% Subsidiary of POWERGRID Corporation of India Ltd.)

Registered Office: B-9, Qutab Institutional Area, Katwaria Sarai, New Delhi 110 016

1. The Petitioner above-named has filed a petition before the Central Electricity Regulatory Commission, New Delhi for determination of Tariff from DOCO to 31-03-2029 for **Project-1:** "Implementation of Bus Sectionalizer at 400kV level of 765/400/220kV Fatehgarh-III PS (Section-2)", **Project-2:** "Transmission system for evacuation of power from REZ in Rajasthan (20GW) under Phase-III Part E1", **Project-3:** "Transmission system for evacuation of power from REZ in Rajasthan (20GW) under Phase-III Part E2".
2. The beneficiaries of the Transmission system are: (a) Ajmer Vidyut Vitran Nigam Ltd. (b) Jaipur Vidyut Vitran Nigam Ltd. (c) Jodhpur Vidyut Vitran Nigam Ltd. (d) Punjab State Electricity Corporation Limited (e) Haryana Power Purchase Centre (f) Jammu & Kashmir Power Corporation Ltd. (g) Uttar Pradesh Power Corporation Ltd. (h) BSES Yamuna Power Ltd. (i) BSES Rajdhani Power Ltd. (j) Tata Power Delhi Distribution Ltd. (k) Chandigarh Electricity Department (l) Uttaranchal Power Corporation Ltd. (m) North Central Railway (n) New Delhi Municipal Council (o) Himachal Pradesh State Electricity Board (p) Central Transmission Utility of India Ltd. (q) Fatehgarh-III & IV Transmission Ltd. (r) Beawar Transmission Ltd. & Fatehgarh-III Beawar Transmission Ltd.
3. Capacity of the transformer, number of bays of the transmission system:

Project	Transformer Capacity (MVA)	Reactor Capacity (MVAR)	No of Bays		
			765kV	400kV	220kV
Bus Sectionalizer at 400kV level	—	—	—	2	—
Phase-III Part E1	—	2x125	2	2	—
Phase-III Part E2	2x1500 & 2x500	—	2	4	2

4. Approved capital cost of the project (Rs. in lakh)- **Project-1: Rs. 6.93 Crores, Project-2: Rs. 688.74 Crores, Project-3: Rs. 428.30 Crores**
5. Capital cost on the date of commercial operation (Rs. in lakh):

Asset	Asset Name	Approved capital cost of the project	
		FR	Actual
***Project-1:** "Implementation of Bus Sectionalizer at 400kV level of 765/400/220kV Fatehgarh-III PS (Section-2)".*			
Asset-1	400kV Bus Sectionalizer Bay 433 of 400kV Bus-4 and 400kV Bus-6 at Fatehgarh-III PS	346.50	203.52
Asset-2	400kV Bus Sectionalizer Bay 434 of 400kV Bus-1 and 400kV Bus-5 at Fatehgarh-III PS	346.50	206.04
***Project-2:** "Transmission system for evacuation of power from REZ in Rajasthan (20GW) under Phase-III Part E1"*			
Asset-1	125MVAr, 420kV bus reactor-3 along with associated bays at Fatehgarh-III Substation	2615.66	3103.67
Asset-2	125MVAr, 420kV bus reactor-4 along with associated bays at Fatehgarh-III Substation	2615.67	3105.37
Asset-3	02 nos 765kV Line Bays at Fatehgarh-III PS for TBCB line	2933.62	3993.14
***Project-3:** "Transmission system for evacuation of power from REZ in Rajasthan (20GW) under Phase-III Part E2"*			
Asset-1	1x1500MVA, 765/400kV, ICT-4 along with associated bays at Fatehgarh-III Substation	11124.40	11067.84
Asset-2	1x1500MVA, 765/400kV, ICT-5 along with associated bays at Fatehgarh-III Substation	11124.40	11064.66
Asset-3	1x500MVA, 400/220kV ICT-9 along with associated bays at Fatehgarh-III Substation	4783.40	4751.93
Asset-4	1x500MVA, 400/220kV ICT-10 along with associated bays at Fatehgarh-III Substation	4673.40	4573.84

Authority which has approved the Capital Cost: Board of Directors

6. Scheduled date of commercial operation and actual date of Commercial operation:

Project Name	SCOD	COD
Project-1: *Implementation of Bus Sectionalizer at 400kV level of 765/400/220kV Fatehgarh-III PS (Section-2)*	01.01.2025 or matching time frame of transmission system for evacuation of power from REZ in Rajasthan (20GW) under Phase-III, Part-E1, whichever is later.	Asset-1: 02.12.2025 (Actual) Asset-2: 30.03.2026 (Actual)
Project-2: *Transmission system for evacuation of power from REZ in Rajasthan (20GW) under Phase-III Part E1"*	01.02.2025 or matching time frame of Transmission system for evacuation of power from REZ in Rajasthan (20GW) under Phase-III Part A1	Asset-1: 30.03.2026 (Actual) Asset-2: 18.04.2026 (Actual) Asset-3: 30.03.2026 (Proposed)
Project-3: *Transmission system for evacuation of power from REZ in Rajasthan (20GW) under Phase-III Part E2"*	Asset-1: 31.03.2025, Asset-2: 30.06.2025, Asset-3: 31.03.2025, Asset-4: 30.06.2025, Or evacuation requirement beyond 3000MW cumulative at Fatehgarh-3 (new section) & Fatehgarh-4 PS, whichever is later	Asset-1: 01.04.2026 (Proposed) Asset-2: 02.04.2026 (Proposed) Asset-3: 31.03.2026 (Actual) Asset-4: 02.04.2026 (Actual)

7. Details of tariff :

(Rs. in lakhs)

Assets	2024-25	2025-26	2026-27	2027-28	2028-29
Project-1					
Asset-1	0.00	18.03	58.59	62.20	64.98
Asset-2	0.00	0.31	59.27	63.24	65.50
Project-2:					
Asset-1	0.00	2.10	414.45	459.39	484.09
Asset-2	0.00	0.00	398.65	460.63	484.60
Asset-3	0.00	2.62	525.37	592.23	629.24
Project-3:					
Asset-1	0.00	0.00	1734.28	1904.17	2007.20
Asset-2	0.00	0.00	1719.72	1895.95	2003.55
Asset-3	0.00	1.90	737.47	802.53	841.32
Asset-4	0.00	0.00	446.85	659.75	790.86

8. A copy of the petition made for determination of tariff is posted on the website https://apps.powergrid.in/cerc/docs/TBCB-PRTL/2026/06/
9. The suggestions and objections, if any, on the proposals for determination of tariff contained in the petition may be filed by any person, including the beneficiary through the e-filing portal of the Commission, with a copy to the Petitioner within 30 days of publication of this notice.

Sd/-
Shri Rajesh Kumar Sharma
Project In-charge

Place: GURUGRAM
Date: 03.07.2026

PG/CC/Notice-38/Advt-41/2026-27

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No: 4420262027 **Dated: 30.06.2026**

E-TENDERING TENDER NOTICE

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)/ North Central Railway/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites E-Tenders on prescribed form for the following work up to **13:30 hrs** on **22.07.2026.** The details of the Tender are as under:-

S.N.: 01 **Tender No.: 108, Name of Work:** Provision of a pathways at various stations under Sr. DEN/I/PRYJ.

Approx Cost (Rs.): 9,73,63,764.88 | **Bid Security (Rs.):** 19,47,300/-

Completion Period: 12 Month, **Date of Opening of tender: 22.07.2026**

Eligibility Criteria for similar work: Any Civil Engineering work

S.N.: 02 **Tender No.: 109, Name of Work:** Combined Tender (A)Type-II quarters at Jhingura (JHG 10 Nos) and Bheerpur (BEP 08 Nos) under Sr.DEN/I/PRYJ. (B) Replacement of severely deteriorated Relay hut (RH-2) between NYN-PRYJ including indoor S&T installations under Sr.DEN/I/PRYJ.

Approx Cost (Rs.): 5,46,81,916.68 | **Bid Security (Rs.):** 10,93,600/-

Completion Period: 12 Month, **Date of Opening of tender: 22.07.2026**

Eligibility Criteria for similar work: Construction of Building.

Note: 1. Tender on line can be submitted up to **13:30 hrs.** of tender opening date. **2.** The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders are available on Website **www.ireps.gov.in.** up to **13:30 hrs.** on the due date of tender opening. **1503/26 (D)**

North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPRONCR

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Letter No. DRM/C/AGRA/PAY & USE/POLICY/2018 Date- 30.06.2026

E-Auction Notice

On behalf of the President of India, **The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager-North Central Railway- Agra** invites E-Auction as per categories given as under:-

Category: Normal Pay & Use | **Auction Catalogue No.:** PNU-AGRA-26-A

Asset Details: Manning of Normal Pay & Use Toilet (IRFC) on Operation and Maintenance (O&M) basis at Agra Fort Railway Station.

E-Auction Start Date and Time: Date- **16.07.2026** Time:- **12.00**

E-Auction End Date and Time: Date- **16.07.2026** Time:- **12.30**

Note:- Prospective bidders are requested to visit e-Auction Leasing Module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wise details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number. **1489/26 FA**

North central railways @CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

millenniumpost
FRIDAY, 3 JULY, 2026 | NEW DELHI

The Belgian job

Belgium come back from two goals down to beat Senegal 3-2 in extra time

SEATTLE: Belgium overturned a two-goal deficit and scored from the penalty spot deep into extra time to beat Senegal 3-2 on Wednesday in the biggest comeback of the World Cup so far.

Senegal held a 2-0 lead with just 5 minutes of regulation time remaining but late goals by Romelu Lukaku and Youri Tielemans pushed the Round of 32 match into extra time.

Tielemans completed Belgium's comeback by converting a penalty in the 125th minute of the game – the latest goal in World Cup history.

"Being part of this comeback is a proud moment because I scored the last two goals to give the team the win today. I'm very proud of that to be able to help the team to score goals and bring us over the line," Tielemans said.

He was fouled with only seconds to go and with a penalty shootout looming, and the referee awarded the spot kick after a video review, ignoring protests from the Senegal team.

"I do not want to interpret the decision. We all have different interpretations when it comes to awarding a penalty," Senegal coach Pape Thiaw said. "I'd rather not comment, not interpreting the referee's decision."

Belgium's Youri Tielemans celebrates after scoring the winning goal — AP

The win for Belgium marked the second time in the last 11 World Cups that a team trailed by two or more goals in the knockout round and advanced. Belgium also did so in a 3-2 victory over Japan in the round of 16 at the 2018 tournament.

"Senegal deserved to win," Belgium coach Rudi Garcia said. "But, I am happy it was us."

Many of the key players from the Belgium team that finished in third place in Russia in 2018 were instrumental to Wednesday's victory. Lukaku, who leads his nation in goals scored, came off the bench to get Belgium back into the match by scoring in the 86th minute, setting the scene for Tielemans to force extra time.

"It is a cruel loss, as we were good in the game," Thiaw said. "We had the advantage. We were leading 2-0. However a football match is not an 85-minute one. Belgium came back, and we were not able to deal with that ... We must congratulate Belgium as they progress." Belgium are back in the Round of 16 for the third time in four tournaments. AGENCIES

125
Tielemans converted a penalty in the 125th minute – the latest goal in WC history

Balogun sees red in US win

SANTA CLARA: Folarin Balogun's night in the World Cup's round of 32 was a roller coaster of emotions.

It began with his third goal of the tournament to put the United States in the lead against Bosnia-Herzegovina and ended prematurely when he was given a red card early in the second half that will force him to miss the next game. "It's so unfortunate honestly," teammate Christian Pulisic said following Wednesday's 2-0 win. "It just seems so harsh for us to get that. He's done so much for us, and now we got his back. If he has to miss the next game, it's just ridiculous for something like that."

Balogun celebrated a goal with The Silencer move used by the NBA's LeBron James — twice — but the first time he put the ball in the net the goal was disallowed for offside. He received a red card from Brazilian referee Raphael Claus for stepping on Tarik Muharemovic's ankle. AGENCIES

MINNOWS' FAIRYTALE RUN AT STAKE

Cape Verde face Argentina in a David vs Goliath battle

MIAMI: By any measure, Cape Verde should have next to no chance of knocking Argentina and Lionel Messi out of the World Cup on Friday, but the Africans have huge confidence in their ability to defy the odds and keep their fairytale debut campaign alive.

Draws with former World Cup winners Spain and Uruguay helped them into the knockout stage and far from cursing their luck at having to play the reigning champions in the round of 32, assistant coach Humberto Bettencourt said this week that it would be "a pleasure" to face the Albiceleste.

"Statistics are theories. Football — as many results throughout history have shown — proves that what really counts is what happens inside the four lines," he told reporters at the team's camp in Tampa on Sunday. "They gave us one percent before, and now four percent is irrelevant to us. We focus much more on our ambitions, our expectations, and above all on the value that defines this working group."

Bettencourt said Cape Verde would not be changing their style measurably to contain the world champions and had no plans to man-mark Messi in an attempt to nullify the threat of the little Argentine general.

Leandro Paredes, Lionel Messi and Alexis Mac Allister train — AP

Messi expected to start against African surprise package

"We consider Messi to be a player who makes a difference," Bettencourt added. "But we always look at the collective — the combinations that can be created, the spaces they may try to open up for Messi."

The least populous nation ever to make the knockout rounds of a World Cup, Cape Verde's campaign has not only raised the profile of the squad but also put the entire island-nation on the map.

People have migrated from Cape Verde throughout its history -- the World Cup squad includes players born in the Netherlands, Portugal, France, the United States and Ireland -- including a sizeable number to Argentina.

Bettencourt, the only member of the Cape Verde delegation to speak to the media this week, confirmed that Telmo Arcanjo was 50-50 for the Argentina game because of a leg injury. The skilful midfielder did not train with the team on Wednesday. AGENCIES

SUPER RAPID & BLITZ CROATIA

Pragg downs Keymer, checks into joint 2nd

ZAGREB: Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa began his campaign in the Zagreb leg of the Grand Chess Tour with a victory over top seed Vincent Keymer of Germany before drawing his next two games to finish the opening day of the rapid section in joint second place.

Praggnanandhaa held France's Maxime Vachier-Lagrave and compatriot and world champion D Gukesh in hard-fought draws to end the day on four points, here on Wednesday.

Alireza Firouzja of France emerged sole leader on five points after winning his first two games and drawing with Anish Giri of the Netherlands in the third round. With each rapid win worth two points, Firouzja moved ahead of Praggnanandhaa, Giri, Vachier-Lagrave and Keymer, who recovered with two wins. AGENCIES

Swiatek powers past Pliskova as Zverev stands tall

LONDON: Defending champion Iga Swiatek cleared a potentially dangerous early hurdle with ease as she defeated former world No.1 Karolina Pliskova to reach Round three at Wimbledon on Thursday.

Czech 34-year-old Pliskova, back on the rise after an ankle injury almost ended her career, landed some heavy artillery on Centre Court but was no match for Swiatek, who won 6-1 6-3.

Swiatek, aiming to break the so-called champion's curse and become the first woman for a decade to retain the Wimbledon crown, looked sharp in the sunshine, taking the opening set in 25 minutes before being forced to work a bit harder.

Alexander Zverev makes a return to Valentin Royer — AP

She has now reached the last-32 stage at 26 successive Grand Slam tournaments dating back to the 2019 US Open — a record only bettered by Martina Navratilova and Conchita Martinez.

Zverev on track

French Open champion Alexander Zverev continued his bid for a second straight Grand Slam trophy as the German beat unseeded Valentin Royer 6-1 6-3 7-6(3) to move into the third round.

Just weeks after ending his long wait for a maiden Major at Roland Garros, Zverev barely put a foot wrong against his French opponent, taking full control of the Court One contest from the outset and overcoming some late resistance to advance. AGENCIES

Shreyas, Abhishek sparkle but rain wins

CHESTER-LE-STREET: Abhishek Sharma's dynamic 59 and skipper Shreyas Iyer's composed 68 helped India gain a slice of positivity despite their first T20I against England getting abandoned because of incessant rains here on Wednesday.

Their fifties helped India post a competitive 189 for seven, a noticeable change in their batting fortunes after churning out two underwhelming efforts against Ireland in the recent 0-2 series defeat. England's chase of 190 remained a non-starter after the heavens opened up during the innings break. AGENCIES

Shreyas iyer in action — BCCI

Leisure

She talked about her experience of working with Shaheer and Avinash Mishra

'It truly felt like a homecoming'

Nimrit Kaur Ahluwalia on her time in Punjab while shooting 'Ab Hoga Hisaab'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Amazon MX Player' recently launched 'Ab Hoga Hisaab', a revenge drama steeped in the colours and textures of Punjab. At its core, the show traces the lives of brothers Bobby and Bunty Manocha, whose world is upended by one defining moment that sets everything in motion.

The series is led by Sanjay Kapoor and Shaheer, alongside a stellar ensemble cast including Mouni Roy, Avinash Mishra, Nimrit Kaur Ahluwalia, Harman Singha and Aasheema Vardaan in pivotal roles.

Talking about her experience of working with Shaheer and Avinash Mishra and sharing one of her favourite behind-the-scenes memories, Nimrit shared, "Both of them have been an absolute treat to work with. There is a sense of mutual respect, admiration and ease that all three of us share. We were incredibly receptive to each other's energies during scenes and I think that comes through beautifully in the episodes."

"One of my favourite memories was a day when the three of us simply explored the city, shared meals and spoke openly about our lives. That sense of trust and camaraderie made working together even more special and reflected in our performances," she added.

Speaking about her time in Punjab, Nimrit said, "I absolutely love Patiala. I have been visiting since childhood because I have cousins there. Plus, during my time at law school, my college was affiliated with Punjabi University Patiala and we would often visit RGNLU for fests."

'Bollywood was never my plan'

Zeenat Aman on how her father's illustrious film career had little influence on her childhood

Long before she became one of Hindi cinema's biggest stars and a defining style icon of the 1970s, Zeenat Aman had an entirely different future in mind. An avid reader with academic ambitions, she never dreamed of becoming an actor. In fact, despite being the daughter of 'Mughal-e-Azam' writer Amanullah Khan, Zeenat said she grew up with almost no exposure to Hindi cinema. Instead, she planned to pursue higher studies and possibly build a life outside India. But a chance entry into modelling led to beauty pageants, which eventually opened the doors to films, leaving her graduation unfinished and changing the course of her life forever.

The veteran actress's potential was discovered by the evergreen actor Dev Anand

Speaking to Shubra Aiyappa, Zeenat reflected on how her father's illustrious film career had little influence on her childhood. "It is true that my father was a prolific writer and exceptional in the work that he did in films. However, I didn't live with my father. My parents separated when I was two and I was brought up by my mother. Of course, I love him and miss him, but there was no great cinematic influence. It was only much later, as an adult, that I realised the quality of his work," she said.

The veteran actress admitted that acting was never part of her plan. "I wasn't looking forward to the cinema." AGENCIES

'THERE ARE MOMENTS I'LL NEVER FORGET'

DANNY GLOVER REVEALS HE HAS ALZHEIMER'S DISEASE

Actor and activist Danny Glover, best known for starring as an easygoing police officer in the 'Lethal Weapon' franchise, revealed he has Alzheimer's disease.

The four-time Emmy Award nominee, who turns 80 on July 22, told 'Today' and 'People' magazine that he was diagnosed with the progressive, memory-destroying disease three years ago.

"I'm still not accepting in my mind all parts of it," he told 'People' magazine. "There are the moments that you keep remembering that validate the fact that you can remember stuff. And there are moments I'll never forget."

'I'm still not accepting in my mind all parts of it,' says the actor and activist

More than six million people in the United States and millions more around the world have Alzheimer's, the most common form of dementia.

Glover earned four Emmy Award nominations and an honorary Oscar in 2022. Other awards came from the NAACP and Black Entertainment Television and he received nominations from the Screen Actors Guild.

The actor also served as a goodwill ambassador for the United Nations Development Program from 1998 to 2004. It focuses on poverty, disease and economic development in Africa, Latin America and the Caribbean. AGENCIES